Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 8 · DAYS 200-234

Conquest and Settlement

Joshua, Judges, Ruth

God brings his people into rest, partial, fragile, and pointing forward.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."

JOSHUA 24:15

God's victories and keeping in the land (Psalms 114, 46, 76), with prayers of trust and repentance (16, 23, 130).

UNIT 8

In this unit

WEEK 29

200	Joshua 1:1-2:24	*Reading*
201	Joshua 3:1-5:15	*Reading*
202	Psalm 114	*Psalm*
203	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 30

204	Psalm 66:1-12	*Psalm*
205	Joshua 6:1-8:35	*Reading*
206	Joshua 9:1-10:43	*Reading*
207	Joshua 11:1-12:24	*Reading*
208	Joshua 13:1-17:18	*Reading*
209	Psalm 16	*Psalm*
210	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 31

211	Psalm 23	*Psalm*
212	Joshua 18:1-19:51	*Reading*
213	Joshua 20:1-22:34	*Reading*
214	Joshua 23:1-24:33	*Reading*
215	Judges 1:1-3:31	*Reading*
216	Judges 4:1-5:31	*Reading*
217	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 32

218	Psalm 46	*Psalm*
219	Psalm 76	*Psalm*
220	Judges 6:1-8:35	*Reading*
221	Judges 9:1-10:18	*Reading*

222	Judges 11:1-12:15	*Reading*
223	Judges 13:1-14:20	*Reading*
224	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 33

225	Judges 15:1-16:31	*Reading*
226	Psalm 130	*Psalm*
227	Psalm 40:1-10	*Psalm*
228	Judges 17:1-18:31	*Reading*
229	Judges 19:1-21:25	*Reading*
230	Ruth 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
231	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 34

232	Ruth 3:1-4:22	*Reading*
233	Psalm 127; Psalm 128	*Psalm*
234	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 200 · WEEK 29

Joshua 1:1-2:24

Joshua commissioned; Rahab and the spies, faith and the scarlet cord

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 1:1-2:24. Moses is dead, and the people stand on the east bank of the Jordan. Read chapter 1 as a commissioning and chapter 2 as a story about two very different kinds of faith: the nation's leader gathering courage, and a pagan prostitute in Jericho staking her life on a God she has only heard about.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Last week you closed the wilderness books with Moses' death on Mount Nebo. The man who led Israel out of Egypt and received the law at Sinai will not enter the land. Now a new leader steps forward. Joshua has been Moses' assistant since the early days of the exodus, and he was one of the two spies who trusted God at Kadesh, forty years ago. Israel now stands where their parents stood, at the edge of the promised land. Will this generation believe God where the last one did not? The book of Joshua tells how God keeps the promise he swore to Abraham, and it begins with one command repeated again and again: be strong and courageous.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God speaks to Joshua directly after Moses' death: "Moses my servant is dead. Now therefore arise, go over this Jordan" (1:2).
2. The promise is stated in the widest terms, from the wilderness to Lebanon and from the Euphrates to the Great Sea (1:4).
3. God promises, "Just as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you or forsake you" (1:5).

4. The command to be “strong and courageous” appears three times in the opening verses (1:6, 7, 9).
5. Success is tied to meditating on the Book of the Law “day and night” and doing what is written in it (1:8).
6. Joshua sends two spies secretly from Shittim, and they lodge with Rahab the prostitute (2:1).
7. Rahab confesses, “The LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath” (2:11).
8. She asks for kindness, and the spies promise protection if she ties a scarlet cord in her window (2:12-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with God’s word to Joshua, and the first thing it does is link the future to the past. “Moses my servant is dead.” The leader has changed, but the promise has not. God does not say, “I will be with you if you prove yourself.” He says, “Just as I was with Moses, I will be with you.” Joshua’s strength will not come from his résumé but from the presence of God. This is why the command to be courageous keeps coming back. Courage in the Bible is never self-confidence. It is the confidence of someone who has been promised that God goes with him.

Notice what makes Joshua strong. It is not a battle plan. It is the book of the law. “This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night.” Joshua is told that success, in the sense of walking wisely and faithfully, comes through Scripture. This is the same pattern as Psalm 1, which you will read soon. The leader of God’s people is first a man under God’s word. The people’s response in the rest of chapter 1 is also striking. They pledge to obey Joshua just as they obeyed Moses, but they add a condition that matters: “Only may the LORD your God be with you, as he was with Moses.” They know that the authority of the leader depends on the presence of God.

Chapter 2 shifts to a very different scene. Joshua sends spies, but the story is not about the spies. It is about a woman in Jericho. Rahab is a Canaanite, a prostitute, and a citizen of a city under God’s judgment. She has no place in the covenant, no history of worship, and no reason to expect mercy. But she has heard what God did at the Red Sea and to the kings east of the Jordan, and she draws a conclusion: “The LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath.” It is one of the great confessions of the Old Testament, and it comes from the mouth of someone the reader would never expect.

She acts on that confession at great risk. She hides the spies, misleads the king's men, and negotiates for the safety of her family. Whatever one concludes about her deception, the text's focus is her faith, and the New Testament will praise it directly. Hebrews 11:31 says, "By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with those who were disobedient." James 2:25 holds her up as an example of faith that shows itself in works. She is not saved by her works. She is saved because she believed, and her works show it.

The scarlet cord is a quiet image of rescue. Like the blood on the doorposts of the Passover, a visible sign marks the house that will be spared when judgment comes. Christians have long seen in it a picture of the blood of Christ, and even if the text does not say so explicitly, the pattern is clear: judgment will fall on Jericho, and those who take refuge in the way God has provided will be saved. Rahab will become part of Israel. Matthew 1:5 names her in the genealogy of Jesus. A Canaanite prostitute is an ancestor of the Messiah.

STEP 5

Connection

The commissioning of Joshua echoes the commissioning of Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3) and the promise of presence in Deuteronomy 31:6-8. The call to meditate on the law anticipates Psalm 1. Rahab's confession is the Old Testament's counterpart to the Gentile faith of the centurion (Matthew 8) and the Canaanite woman (Matthew 15). The scarlet cord recalls the Passover blood in Exodus 12. Rahab is named in Matthew 1:5, Hebrews 11:31, and James 2:25.

STEP 6

Application

First, take courage from the grounds of Joshua's courage. God does not tell you to be brave because you are capable. He tells you to be brave because he is with you. Think of one situation this week where you feel inadequate, and pray Joshua 1:9 over it.

Second, notice the link between courage and Scripture. If you want to be steady in a shaky season, ask what place God's word has in your days. What is it shaping in you right now?

Third, let Rahab reshape your idea of who God saves. If you are tempted to think some people are too far gone, remember that God rescued a prostitute from Jericho and put her in the line of Christ. And if you are the one who feels too far gone, she is your encouragement.

Fourth, think about what you have heard of God's works and how you have responded. Rahab acted on what she heard. What does your life show you believe about him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a situation where you feel inadequate, and pray Joshua 1:9 over it.

Ask him to keep his word on your lips and in your mind.

Thank him that he saves those who seem too far gone, as he did Rahab.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 201 · WEEK 29

Joshua 3:1-5:15

Crossing the Jordan; circumcision renewed; the Passover kept

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 3:1-5:15. It is a long reading, but the three chapters tell one story: the nation crosses the Jordan, builds a memorial, is renewed in covenant signs, and meets the commander of the LORD's army. Notice how often the ark, the stones, and the Passover remind Israel what God has done.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The spies have returned from Jericho with good news: the inhabitants are melting in fear. But there is still a river between Israel and the land, and in the spring it is at flood stage. Forty years earlier, God parted the Red Sea for their parents. Now he will do something similar for the children, but it will happen in a different way. The priests carrying the ark will step into the water first. Once across, Israel will pause at Gilgal for three acts that prepare them for the conquest: they will set up a memorial, renew circumcision, and keep the Passover. Only then will the commander of the LORD's army appear. The order matters. Israel is not ready to fight until they are ready to worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people are told to follow the ark at a distance of about two thousand cubits, so everyone can see where it goes (3:3-4).
2. Joshua tells them, "Consecrate yourselves, for tomorrow the LORD will do wonders among you" (3:5).
3. The waters stop only when the priests' feet touch the edge of the Jordan, even though it is overflowing its banks (3:13-15).

4. The priests stand firm in the middle of the dry riverbed until all Israel has crossed (3:17).
5. Twelve stones are taken from the Jordan to Gilgal, as a memorial "so that all the peoples of the earth may know that the hand of the LORD is mighty" (4:20-24).
6. The generation born in the wilderness had not been circumcised, so Joshua circumcises them at Gilgal (5:2-7).
7. The manna ceases the day after they eat the produce of the land (5:12).
8. Joshua meets a man with a drawn sword who says he is "commander of the army of the LORD" and tells Joshua to remove his sandals, because the place is holy (5:13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The crossing of the Jordan deliberately echoes the crossing of the Red Sea. The author wants us to see that the God who brought Israel out of Egypt is the same God who now brings them in. But there are differences. At the Red Sea, Moses stretched out a staff and the waters parted, and Israel crossed while the enemy chased them. At the Jordan, no enemy pursues. The challenge is not escape but entry. And the miracle begins only when the priests step in. They have to walk into a flooded river before the water stops. Faith precedes sight. God does not part the waters in advance. He asks his people to take a step of trust, and then he acts.

The ark is the center of the story. It is the symbol of God's throne and presence, and it goes first. The people follow at a distance, which keeps the focus on the ark and not on the carriers. This is the pattern of the whole conquest: Israel does not win because of its army but because God goes before them. The lesson for every believer is simple. We do not go anywhere that God has not first gone.

Then the people build a memorial. Twelve stones, one for each tribe, are taken from the middle of the Jordan and piled up at Gilgal. The purpose is explained twice: so that future children will ask, "What do these stones mean?" and the parents will tell them the story. God's people are a remembering people. Spiritual memory does not happen automatically. It needs signs, stories, and rituals that pass faith from one generation to the next. This is the logic of baptism and the Lord's Supper, and it is the reason your own daily reading matters.

Chapter 5 is surprising. Israel has crossed the river, and the Canaanite kings are afraid, yet Joshua stops to circumcise every man. It seems like a terrible time to put the army out of action. But God is teaching a priority. The sign of the Abrahamic covenant had been neglected in the wilderness. Before the people take the land, they must renew the mark that

says they belong to God. Then they celebrate Passover and eat the produce of the land. The manna stops. God has provided what they need in the wilderness, and now he provides from the inheritance he promised.

Finally, a mysterious figure appears. Joshua, a warrior, asks whether he is for Israel or for their enemies. The answer is "No." The commander of the LORD's army has not come to take sides. He has come to take command. Joshua falls on his face and removes his sandals, just as Moses did at the burning bush. The figure is likely a pre-incarnate appearance of the Son, the one who leads God's armies. Joshua is not the real captain of the host. The real captain has arrived.

STEP 5

Connection

The crossing of the Jordan echoes the crossing of the Red Sea (Exodus 14) and anticipates Elijah and Elisha crossing the same river (2 Kings 2) and the baptism of Jesus there (Matthew 3). The memorial stones recall Deuteronomy 6:20-25. Circumcision renews the sign of Genesis 17. The manna's end ties to Exodus 16. The commander's command to remove sandals repeats Exodus 3:5, and the same figure appears as the "angel of the LORD" throughout the Old Testament.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about what step of faith God may be asking you to take before he shows you the outcome. The priests had to get their feet wet. Ask the Lord for the courage to take one step this week.

Second, build your own memorial. Write down three things God has done for you in the last year, and put the list somewhere you will see it. Tell someone younger in the faith about one of them.

Third, ask yourself what must be set right before you can move forward. Israel could not conquer until the covenant sign was renewed. Is there something in your relationship with God that has been neglected?

Fourth, notice that the commander is not on your side. He is in charge. Bow to him in prayer this week and ask him what he wants, rather than asking him to bless your plans.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you to follow where he leads.

Thank him for what he has done, and ask him to help you tell the story to someone else.

Tell him about a “Jordan” you are facing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

“Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.”

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 202 · WEEK 29

Psalm 114

When Israel went out of Egypt, the Jordan fled

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 114 aloud. It is only eight verses long, and it is one of the most compressed poems in the Psalter. It looks back at the exodus and the crossing of the Jordan and sees the whole creation reacting to the presence of God. Read it as a celebration of the two crossings you have been reading about.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 114 is one of the Hallel psalms, sung at Passover. It may have been sung in the temple long after the days of Joshua, as Israel remembered how God brought them out of Egypt and into the land. It pairs two events you have just read about: the splitting of the Red Sea and the stopping of the Jordan. The psalm treats them as one great act of deliverance. Its poetry is bold and playful. It does not explain how the miracles happened. It simply asks: what could make the sea flee, the river turn back, and the mountains skip like rams? The answer is the presence of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins with the exodus: “When Israel went out from Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language” (v. 1).
2. Judah became God’s “sanctuary” and Israel his “dominion” (v. 2). The people are his dwelling place.
3. “The sea looked and fled; Jordan turned back” (v. 3). The two crossings are placed side by side.
4. The mountains “skipped like rams” and the hills “like lambs” (v. 4).

5. The psalm asks the sea and river, “What ails you?” (v. 5), as though they were nervous children.
6. The answer is direct: “Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord” (v. 7).
7. The God of Jacob turns rock into “a pool of water” and flint into “a spring of water” (v. 8).
8. The name of God is withheld until verse 7, which heightens the effect.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 114 is a poem about reaction. The first four verses describe what happened in nature when God moved. The sea saw and ran away. The Jordan flowed backward. The mountains leaped. These are not scientific descriptions. They are the poet’s way of showing that creation itself recognizes its Lord. Water, which can drown an army, is no more than a servant. Mountains, which seem immovable, jump like frightened lambs. If the natural world responds this way to the presence of God, how should we?

Then the poet does something delightful. He turns and interrogates the sea and the river. “What ails you, O sea, that you flee?” It is almost comical. The mighty Red Sea and the flooding Jordan, scolded as though they had panicked for no reason. The answer comes in verse 7: “Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob.” The poet has delayed the name of God until this point. For six verses we do not know who made the sea flee. When the name arrives, it carries weight: the Lord, the God of Jacob. This is the God who attached himself to a deceiver and made him Israel. The power that shakes the earth is the same power that is committed to a covenant family.

The last verse is the most surprising. After all the shaking and fleeing, the poem closes with a small, tender image: the God who turns rock into a pool of water. This points back to the water from the rock at Meribah, and to God’s care for his thirsty people in the wilderness. The God who makes mountains skip is also the God who provides a drink for his people. His power and his provision are the same.

For Christians, the psalm tells a bigger story. Israel’s exodus and entry are a pattern. Christ passes through the waters of death and brings his people to an inheritance. Paul says in 1 Corinthians 10:4 that the rock in the wilderness was Christ, and in Hebrews, the land is a shadow of the rest to come. Christian baptism is also described as a crossing: we pass through water out of slavery and into a new life.

STEP 5

Connection

The psalm draws on Exodus 14-15 (the sea), Joshua 3-4 (the Jordan), and Exodus 17 and Numbers 20 (the water from the rock). It belongs to the Hallel, Psalms 113-118, sung at Passover, and so Jesus and his disciples likely sang it at the Last Supper (Matthew 26:30). Paul interprets the rock as Christ in 1 Corinthians 10:1-4.

STEP 6

Application

Let this psalm reorder your sense of scale. The things that loom large in your life, such as deadlines, diagnoses, or conflicts, are like the Red Sea and the Jordan. They look immovable until God shows up. Name one thing you are facing, and tell it, in prayer, that it is small compared to the presence of the Lord.

Notice also the God of Jacob. If God attached himself to someone like Jacob, he can bind himself to you. His power is not set against your weakness. It is committed to your good.

Finally, take a drink. When you are thirsty spiritually, remember the rock and the pool. Christ is the source. Come to him and drink.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tremble before the God who turns back seas and rivers, in your own words.

Ask him to turn the hard places in your life into springs of water.

Thank him that he is bound to his people by covenant.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 203 · WEEK 29

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the wilderness books with the review of Unit 7, and you crossed the Jordan with Joshua. Take a quiet moment today to sit with the opening of Joshua. Read Joshua 1:1-9 again slowly if you can, and let the promise of God's presence settle in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

REST

Meditation

Joshua 1:9 is a command wrapped around a promise, and the promise is what holds the command up.

"Have I not commanded you?" God begins with a reminder. He has already spoken. Joshua does not need a new word. He needs to believe the one he has.

"Be strong and courageous." This is the third time in nine verses that the words appear. Courage is not a feeling that arrives on its own. It is a choice made in response to what God has said. Joshua will be afraid. God does not deny it. He commands courage because fear is real.

“Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed.” The two words describe fear that shakes you from the inside and discouragement that drains you from outside. Both are answered by the same thing.

“For the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” This is the reason. Not “because you are strong,” not “because you are well prepared,” but because he is with you. Every step into unknown territory is accompanied.

Notice the last phrase: wherever you go. Joshua would go into the Jordan, into Jericho, into battle, and into long years of leadership. The promise follows him into all of it. And for the Christian, the promise is stronger still. Jesus said, “I am with you always, to the end of the age” (Matthew 28:20). Carry this verse into the places you dread this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the wilderness books with the Unit 7 review, spending time in Psalm 119, the long song of delight in God’s word. Then you began Unit 8 and the book of Joshua. You heard God commission a new leader and promise his presence. You met Rahab, the Canaanite woman who confessed that the LORD is God in heaven above and on earth beneath, and who hung a scarlet cord in her window. You watched the priests step into a flooded Jordan and saw the waters stop, you saw twelve stones piled up at Gilgal, and you saw a new generation circumcised and the Passover kept. You met the commander of the LORD’s army, and you sang Psalm 114, in which the sea flees and the mountains skip.

The week taught one lesson in many forms: God keeps his promises, and he goes before his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you most need courage right now? Joshua was not told to feel brave. He was told to be strong because God was with him. Name one situation where fear or discouragement is pressing on you, and write down what it would look like to take one faithful step in it this week.

How does Rahab’s story point you to Christ? She was an outsider under judgment, who heard about God’s works, believed, and took refuge in the way of rescue he provided. A scarlet cord marked her house, and she was brought into God’s people and into the line of the Messiah. How does her story clarify what it means that Jesus saves, not on the basis of who we are, but on the basis of what he has done?

What “memorial stones” help you remember what God has done? Think about the practices, places, or people that keep your faith anchored. Is there one you have neglected? What could you do this week to retell God’s faithfulness to someone else?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Rest in God’s promise to be with you wherever you go.

Thank him for Rahab, and for mercy that reaches outsiders like you.

Tell him what you are leaving in his hands this Sabbath.

DAY 204 · WEEK 30

Psalm 66:1-12

Make a joyful noise; God tested us

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 66:1-12. You read the opening verses of this psalm in Unit 3. Today you read further, to the part where the psalmist remembers the times God tested his people. Notice how the praise turns from the whole earth to the experience of Israel, and how God's discipline is described as both fire and a spacious place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This week begins with a psalm of praise that moves from the global to the personal. The psalmist first calls the whole earth to shout to God, and then recalls the exodus and the crossing of the sea, and finally speaks about the nation's hard experiences. It fits the story of Joshua well. Israel has crossed the Jordan and stands on the edge of a conquest that will test them. The psalm reminds us that God's tests are not meant to destroy but to refine, and that they lead to a place of abundance. It is a good psalm to read as you prepare for the walls of Jericho.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens, "Shout for joy to God, all the earth" (v. 1), and calls people to sing the glory of his name.
2. "Say to God, How awesome are your deeds!" (v. 3). Even enemies cringe before his power.
3. "He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot" (v. 6). Both crossings are recalled.
4. "He rules by his might forever, his eyes keep watch on the nations" (v. 7).
5. God "has kept us among the living and has not let our feet slip" (v. 9).

6. “For you, O God, have tested us; you have tried us as silver is tried” (v. 10).
7. The imagery of hardship is vivid: nets, burdens on the back, men riding over heads, fire and water (vv. 11-12).
8. The psalm ends this section with “yet you have brought us out to a place of abundance” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 66 reminds us that praise and hardship belong together. The psalmist does not say that life has been easy. He says that God has tested his people the way a refiner tests silver, and that the testing was real. Israel went into the net. They felt a heavy weight on their backs. They felt men trample them, and they walked through fire and flood. The psalm does not shrink from describing the pain. And yet it begins with a shout of joy.

What allows the psalmist to praise God in the middle of hardship? The answer is in the sequence. Verses 5-7 remind the people of the God who turned the sea into dry land. Verse 8 says he “has kept us among the living.” The pain was real, but so was God’s presence in it. Every hardship has a boundary that God has set. The fire and water do not overwhelm. They are the way to a place of abundance.

The word “tested” is important. In the Bible, God does not test people to find out something he does not know. He tests to reveal and to refine. A silversmith heats the metal to burn off the dross and leave pure silver. In the same way, God allows pressure so that what is false in our faith will fall away and what is true will remain. This is the same logic you will see in Joshua. The conquest is not only a military campaign but a test of whether Israel will trust God’s word and keep his covenant. Some of the hardest tests will come after the greatest victories.

The final phrase, “a place of abundance,” lifts the eyes. Hardship is not the end of the story. It is a corridor. The God who brings his people through fire and water brings them out into a spacious place. For the Christian, this finds its fullest sense in Christ, who passed through the waters of death, the “fire” of God’s judgment, and rose to the abundance of new life. His people follow him through the same journey, and the end is not loss but fullness.

STEP 5

Connection

The first seven verses recall the exodus (Exodus 14-15) and the Jordan crossing (Joshua 3). The image of refining silver appears in Proverbs 17:3, Zechariah 13:9, and 1 Peter 1:6-7. Isaiah 43:2 promises that God will be with his people through water and fire. The “place of abundance” anticipates the land of promise and the new creation in Revelation 21.

STEP 6

Application

When you face hardship, avoid the two easy conclusions that God has abandoned you or that you have failed some test. Instead, ask what he might be refining. Take ten minutes today to name one area where you have felt pressure, and pray: “Lord, what do you want to burn away, and what do you want to keep?”

Also, practice praising God before the pressure lifts. The psalmist begins with a shout. Choose one song or psalm and sing or read it aloud today, even if your circumstances have not changed.

Finally, remind yourself of the place of abundance. Hardship in Christ is never wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for testing you and keeping you among the living.
- Tell him what pressure you are under and trust him in it.
- Ask him to burn away what does not belong in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 205 · WEEK 30

Joshua 6:1-8:35

Jericho falls; Achan's sin; Ai taken

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 6:1-8:35. These chapters contain some of the best-known stories in the Old Testament and some of the most uncomfortable. Read slowly through the fall of Jericho, then through Achan's sin and Israel's humiliating defeat at Ai, and finally through the renewal of the covenant on Mount Ebal. Ask throughout: what does this show about God's holiness, and about the seriousness of sin?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has crossed the Jordan, and the first fortified city stands in the way. Jericho is the gateway to the land. God does not give Joshua a battle plan in the usual sense. He gives him a worship procession. For six days, the army will march around the walls with the ark and seven priests blowing rams' horns, and on the seventh day they will march seven times and shout. Victory is God's gift. But right after the high of Jericho comes the low of Ai. A single man's sin brings defeat on the whole community. These chapters teach that God's people are called to trust his power and to take his holiness seriously.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The LORD says to Joshua, "See, I have given Jericho into your hand" (6:2). The victory is announced before the battle.
2. The army marches around the city for six days in silence, and on the seventh day shouts as the walls fall (6:3-20).
3. Everything in Jericho is placed under the ban (herem) and devoted to the LORD, except Rahab and her family, who are spared (6:17-25).

4. Achan takes a robe from Shinar, silver, and a bar of gold from the devoted things and hides them in his tent (7:1, 21).
5. Israel is routed at Ai, and thirty-six men die. Joshua tears his clothes and falls on his face (7:4-6).
6. The LORD says, "Israel has sinned; they have transgressed my covenant" (7:11). The community is treated as a unit.
7. Achan is identified by lot, confesses, and is judged along with his family (7:16-26).
8. After the victory at Ai, Joshua builds an altar on Mount Ebal and reads the blessings and curses of the law to the whole assembly (8:30-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The fall of Jericho is a story about who wins battles. No siege equipment, no tactics, no armies are needed. God hands over the city to a people who march, worship, and shout. The point is made so clearly that nobody can miss it: the walls fall by faith. Hebrews 11:30 summarizes it, "By faith the walls of Jericho fell down after they had been encircled for seven days." The first victory in the land belongs entirely to God. It is also the first fruits of the conquest, and everything in the city is devoted to the LORD.

This is the difficult theme of herem, the ban. Everything in Jericho was to be destroyed. Modern readers rightly feel the weight of this. How can we read it? First, the Bible presents this as a specific, unrepeatable act of divine judgment on a people whose sin had reached its full measure. Genesis 15:16 says that the iniquity of the Amorites was not yet complete in Abraham's day, which means God waited four hundred years before bringing judgment. Deuteronomy 9:4 says it was "because of the wickedness of these nations" that God drove them out, and warns Israel not to think they are being given the land because of their own righteousness. Second, Jericho is judged and Rahab is saved. The conquest does not teach that Israel is better than its neighbors. It teaches that God is holy, that sin is judged, and that the only safety is to take refuge in him. Third, the command is narrowly bound to the original conquest. The New Testament never uses it as a model for the church. Our weapons are not carnal (2 Corinthians 10:4).

Then chapter 7 shows that this holiness cuts both ways. Achan, an Israelite, takes some of the devoted things. His sin is hidden, but not from God. Israel loses at Ai and thirty-six men die. God's explanation is frightening: "Israel has sinned." The community is bound together, and one man's secret disobedience damages everyone. The text carefully traces Achan's sin in the verbs of Genesis 3: "I saw... I coveted... I took... I hid" (7:21). He is a second Adam in a garden of promise, and his sin brings death.

Joshua's response is instructive. He falls on his face, and God tells him to stand up and deal with the sin. Prayer without repentance is not enough. Achan's judgment is severe, and the valley where it happens is named Achor, meaning "trouble." But the prophets will later turn the name around. Hosea 2:15 promises that God will make the Valley of Achor "a door of hope." God's holiness is not the last word.

The section ends not with a battle but with a covenant renewal. On Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim, Joshua reads the entire law, blessings and curses, to the people as Moses commanded. The conquest is a covenant event. Israel is not simply taking territory. They are living under the word of the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

The collapse of Jericho is recalled in Hebrews 11:30. Rahab's rescue ties back to Joshua 2 and forward to Matthew 1:5. The ban's justification is in Genesis 15:16 and Deuteronomy 9:4-5 and 20:16-18. Achan's sin echoes Genesis 3:6 and anticipates Ananias and Sapphira in Acts 5. The Valley of Achor reappears in Isaiah 65:10 and Hosea 2:15. The covenant ceremony on Ebal fulfills Deuteronomy 11:29 and 27:1-26.

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what your "walls" might be. Where are you trying to win by effort when God asks you to trust and obey? Take one concrete step of worshipful obedience this week, and leave the outcome with him.

Second, take Achan's story as a warning about hidden sin. No sin is private. Is there something you are concealing, perhaps a habit, a debt, a relationship, or a resentment? Bring it into the light, first to God, and then to a trusted friend. Concealment is how small sins grow.

Third, remember that Christ is our Joshua. His name is the same in Hebrew. He defeats the powers we cannot overcome, and he is also the one who bore the curse of our sin. Hosea's "door of hope" is a picture of what he does with our trouble.

Finally, hold both God's holiness and mercy together. Rahab's rescue and Achan's judgment are on the same pages. Both teach us to fear and love him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to show you any hidden sin and to give you courage to confess it.

Thank him for the victory he gives.

Thank him for turning a valley of trouble into a door of hope.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 206 · WEEK 30

Joshua 9:1-10:43

The Gibeonite deception; the southern campaign

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 9:1-10:43. The first chapter is a story about deception and a hasty oath. The second is a story about a great victory in which God fights from heaven. Notice how the two are connected: the treaty with Gibeon is what pulls Israel into the southern campaign.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Ai, news of Israel's victories has spread across the land. The kings of the hill country gather in an alliance to fight Joshua. But one group has another plan. The Gibeonites, a Hivite people living only a few miles away, decide to trick Israel into a peace treaty by pretending to come from a distant country. They put on worn-out clothing and carry moldy bread. Joshua and the leaders fall for it, and make a covenant with them without asking the LORD. The consequences of that oath will shape Israel's history for centuries. Yet God uses even Israel's mistake to bring about a remarkable day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Gibeonites disguise themselves with old sacks, worn wineskins, patched sandals, and dry, moldy bread (9:4-5).
2. The Israelites "took some of their provisions, but did not ask counsel from the LORD" (9:14).
3. Joshua makes peace with them and the leaders swear an oath (9:15).
4. Three days later the deception is discovered, but the leaders refuse to break the oath: "We have sworn to them by the LORD, the God of Israel" (9:18-19).
5. The Gibeonites are made woodcutters and water carriers for the house of God (9:21-27).

6. Five Amorite kings attack Gibeon, and Joshua marches all night to rescue them (10:5-9).
7. The LORD threw large hailstones from heaven, and more died from the hailstones than the Israelites killed with the sword (10:11).
8. Joshua says, “Sun, stand still at Gibeon,” and the text records, “There has been no day like it before or since, when the LORD heeded the voice of a man” (10:12-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Gibeonite story is a lesson in discernment. Israel has just seen God defeat Jericho and Ai, and they might be tempted to feel that they can handle anything. But the text records a single sentence that explains the problem: “they did not ask counsel from the LORD.” They looked at the bread, they sampled the supplies, and they trusted their own judgment. It was a reasonable-looking decision made without prayer. The lesson for believers is not that every decision needs a miracle, but that confidence in our own wisdom is dangerous. The people who were sure of themselves were fooled by a few moldy crusts.

The oath they swore becomes binding. Even when the leaders realize they have been deceived, they keep their word. This is a remarkable testimony to the seriousness of vows made in God’s name. Psalm 15:4 describes the person who “swears to his own hurt and does not change.” The Gibeonites are spared, but made servants at the sanctuary. Surprisingly, this turns out for their good. They are brought into the worship of Israel’s God, just as Rahab was. Gibeon would later become a city of the Levites and the site of the tabernacle in Solomon’s time. Out of a deception, God brought mercy.

Chapter 10 shows Israel’s loyalty to a vow. When the five kings attack Gibeon, Joshua could have left the Gibeonites to their fate. They had lied to him. But the oath binds him, so he marches all night. And God honors the faithfulness. The LORD throws hailstones, and the sun and moon pause. Whatever one concludes about the exact nature of this event, the author’s point is plain: this was the LORD fighting for Israel. “There has been no day like it before or since, when the LORD heeded the voice of a man.” The statement is stunning. God listens to the prayer of a man. He is not a distant sovereign who ignores his people. He bends to the requests of those who walk in faithfulness.

The chapter also continues the theme of divine warfare. The five kings are brought out, and Joshua has his commanders put their feet on their necks. It is a symbolic act of total victory, and it is an acted parable. The enemies of God’s people will be subdued, and the people share in the victory of their leader. This image will be used again in the New Testament. In Romans 16:20, Paul promises that “the God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.” The conquest looks forward to a greater victory.

STEP 5

Connection

Joshua's failure to ask counsel echoes Numbers 27:21, where Joshua was to consult the LORD through Eleazar. The sanctity of oaths is addressed in Numbers 30 and Psalm 15:4. The Gibeonites' later history appears in 2 Samuel 21:1-9 and 1 Kings 3:4. The hailstones recall the plagues in Exodus 9, and the sun standing still is echoed in Habakkuk 3:11. The feet on the necks of the kings anticipates Psalm 110:1 and 1 Corinthians 15:25.

STEP 6

Application

Make a habit of asking God before you decide. Not only for the big choices, but for the ordinary ones: a commitment, a purchase, a relationship, a job offer. Pause and pray before you say yes. Ask a wise believer to help you see what you might be missing.

Second, take seriously the words you promise. When you give your word, keep it, even when it costs you. A reputation for faithfulness is a witness to the God who keeps his word.

Third, take encouragement from the day the sun stood still. God listens to the prayers of his people. Bring him something that seems too big to ask.

Fourth, see Christ in this story. He saves us when we come to him with nothing, and he brings the deceived and the outsiders near, as he did with Gibeon.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you trust your own judgment without asking God's.

Ask him to teach you to seek his counsel first and to be someone whose word can be trusted.

Thank him that he fights for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 207 · WEEK 30

Joshua 11:1-12:24

The northern campaign; the defeated kings

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 11:1-12:24. Chapter 11 tells of the northern campaign and the summary of Joshua's victories. Chapter 12 is a list of defeated kings, which may seem dry. Read it as a record of God's faithfulness. Pay attention to the repeated phrase "as the LORD had commanded Moses."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The southern campaign is complete. Now, in the north, a larger coalition gathers under Jabin, king of Hazor, with a massive army, "as many as the sand on the seashore," along with horses and chariots. For Israelite infantry, chariots were the most terrifying weapon of the age. The odds look impossible. Yet God speaks to Joshua with the same words he has used before: "Do not be afraid of them." The chapter then steps back and offers a summary of the war and a list of the kings defeated on both sides of the Jordan. It reads like a ledger, and in a sense it is: a record of what God did in fulfillment of what he promised.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jabin of Hazor gathers a coalition of northern kings with a huge army, horses, and chariots (11:1-5).
2. The LORD tells Joshua, "Do not be afraid of them, for tomorrow at this time I will give over all of them" (11:6).
3. Joshua is told to hamstring the horses and burn the chariots with fire (11:6, 9).
4. Hazor, "formerly the head of all those kingdoms," is burned (11:10-11).
5. "Joshua did to them just as the LORD said to him" (11:9), and "as the LORD had commanded Moses his servant, so Moses commanded Joshua" (11:15).

6. “There was not a city that made peace with the people of Israel except the Hivites of Gibeon” (11:19).

7. “It was the LORD’s doing to harden their hearts that they should come against Israel in battle” (11:20).

8. Chapter 12 lists thirty-one defeated kings, beginning with the two east of the Jordan, Sihon and Og (12:1-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The northern campaign shows the pattern of the conquest in miniature: a threat that looks impossible, a word from God, and a victory that comes through obedience. The command to hamstring the horses and burn the chariots is a notable detail. God is teaching Israel not to depend on the military technology of the nations. Psalm 20:7 will later put it this way: “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.” The order is a test of dependence. If Israel keeps the horses, they might start to trust them.

The chapter also reveals something about the nature of the conquest. Verse 20 says it was “the LORD’s doing to harden their hearts.” This is the same language used of Pharaoh. The nations of Canaan were not innocent bystanders who were randomly attacked. They were in rebellion, and the war was an act of judgment. God allowed their resistance to run its course. Many readers struggle with this, and the Bible doesn’t hide it. But Scripture is consistent in how it frames the matter: God judges sin, and he does so with justice. Paul takes up the same theme in Romans 9-11, where hardening and mercy sit together in God’s plan.

The repeated phrase “as the LORD commanded Moses” also deserves attention. Joshua is not an innovator. He is a faithful follower of the word of God. The victories happen because he carries out what has been commanded. The author makes it a refrain, because he wants the reader to see that Israel’s success depends not on military genius but on obedience to a word.

Chapter 12 closes the first half of the book with a list. At first it seems like a dry ledger, but it carries a quiet testimony. God remembers each defeated king. The record is a monument. It tells every generation of Israel that these were real enemies, defeated at real places, by real power. When the people doubt, they can look at the list. The God who did all this will not abandon them. And Christians read the list with a larger horizon. The enemies Christ has defeated are far greater: sin, death, and the devil. The cross and resurrection are the real Jericho, and the church is called to live in light of a victory that is already won.

STEP 5

Connection

The “hardening” language connects to Exodus 4-14 and to Romans 9:17-18. Trust in horses versus the name of the LORD appears in Psalm 20:7, 33:16-17, and Isaiah 31:1. The commands to Moses are in Deuteronomy 7 and 20. Sihon and Og were defeated in Numbers 21, which you read earlier. The theme of enemy kings defeated looks forward to Colossians 2:15, where Christ “disarmed the rulers and authorities.”

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what your chariots are. What do you rely on that is not God: a plan, a savings account, a network of influence? None of these are evil in themselves, but they may be places where trust has quietly moved. Ask the Lord what to release.

Second, make obedience a habit. Joshua succeeded because he did what he was told, even when it did not make military sense. Choose one clear command of Scripture that you have been delaying, and do it this week.

Third, keep a record. Write down a short list of the ways God has defeated something in your life: a habit, a fear, a broken relationship. Read it when you are discouraged.

Fourth, remember that Christ has won the decisive battle. Live from his victory, not toward it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from trusting in chariots and horses, whatever those are in your life.

Ask him to teach you to obey even when his word seems strange.

Thank Christ for disarming the powers that oppose you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 208 · WEEK 30

Joshua 13:1-17:18

Tribal allotments begin, the inheritance [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 121 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 13:1-17:18. This is a long reading in the geographic style of the book, and it can feel like a list. Don't try to memorize the places. Read it for the shape: the land is being divided among the tribes, and God is distributing an inheritance. Keep your eye out for Caleb in chapter 14 and the daughters of Zelophehad in chapter 17.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conquest is over, at least in principle, but there is still much land to be taken. Joshua is old, and God tells him to divide the territory among the tribes so that each can finish the work. The next several chapters read like a land registry. For many modern readers they are the most skippable part of the Bible. But for the first readers, they were among the most precious. This was proof that God had kept his promise to Abraham: he had given his people a place. Each border and town was a statement that this family belongs here. For us, the lists point toward a greater inheritance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Joshua, "You are old and advanced in years, and there remains yet very much land to possess" (13:1).
2. Moses had already given the eastern territory to Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh (13:8-33).
3. "To the tribe of Levi alone Moses gave no inheritance. The LORD God of Israel is their inheritance" (13:33).
4. Caleb, at eighty-five, asks for the hill country of Hebron and says, "Give me this hill country of which the LORD spoke on that day" (14:6-12).

5. Hebron becomes Caleb's inheritance "because he wholly followed the LORD" (14:14).
6. Judah's allotment is the longest and is described first (15:1-63), though Judah could not drive out the Jebusites in Jerusalem (15:63).
7. Ephraim and Manasseh, the sons of Joseph, receive the central hill country, and Ephraim does not drive out the Canaanites in Gezer (16:10).
8. The daughters of Zelophehad ask for and receive an inheritance among their father's brothers (17:3-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The land lists are not an interruption of the story but its fulfillment. From Genesis 12, God had promised Abraham a land. Four hundred years of waiting, a slavery in Egypt, and forty years in the wilderness had passed. Now, tribe by tribe and family by family, the promise is distributed. God keeps his word down to the details of boundary lines. The lists are the opposite of vague spirituality. They show that God's promises have addresses.

Several details shine out. First, the Levites receive no territory because "the LORD God of Israel is their inheritance." This is one of the great lines of the Old Testament. They have cities to live in, but their portion is God himself. It is a picture of what is true for every believer. Whatever else we may have or lack, our true inheritance is the Lord. Psalm 16, which you will read soon, will express the same idea: "The LORD is my chosen portion."

Second, Caleb's request is a remarkable story of long-term faithfulness. He is eighty-five years old, and he asks for the hardest land in the region, a hill country full of giants. He does not ask for retirement. Forty-five years earlier, he and Joshua had stood against the report of the other spies. He says, "I wholly followed the LORD my God." His strength is the same at eighty-five as at forty, and he is ready for the fight. The text marks him out as a model of perseverance. His faith did not fade with age. It deepened.

Third, the daughters of Zelophehad ask for what they are due. God had already promised in Numbers 27 that daughters could inherit when there were no sons, and now they remind Joshua. The story shows God's care for the vulnerable and the importance of claiming what has been promised.

But there are also shadows. Judah cannot drive out the Jebusites. Ephraim does not drive out the Canaanites at Gezer. These small notes of incomplete obedience foreshadow the book of Judges. The land is given, but Israel must take it. Many of God's gifts work this way: the inheritance is secure, but we must live into it. Paul says the same about our salvation, "work out your own salvation… for it is God who works in you" (Philippians 2:12-13).

STEP 5

Connection

The land promise is rooted in Genesis 12:7, 15:18-21, and 17:8. The Levites' inheritance appears in Numbers 18:20 and Deuteronomy 10:9. Caleb's story begins in Numbers 13-14. The daughters of Zelophehad first appear in Numbers 27 and 36. The "inheritance" language runs into the New Testament in Ephesians 1:11-14, Colossians 1:12, and 1 Peter 1:3-4, where believers have an imperishable inheritance kept in heaven.

STEP 6

Application

First, consider your inheritance. If you are in Christ, you have been given the Spirit as a guarantee of an inheritance that cannot fade. Let that anchor your view of what you do and do not have this week.

Second, learn from Caleb. Where might you be tempted to coast in your faith? Ask the Lord for the kind of faith that still asks for the hill country at eighty-five.

Third, notice that Israel's incomplete obedience begins in small places. Is there a "Gezer" in your life, an area of compromise you have chosen not to confront? Name it and ask for help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping his promises down to the last detail.

Ask for a wholehearted faith like Caleb's.

Ask him to show you where you have left territory unclaimed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 209 · WEEK 30

Psalm 16

The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 16 slowly. It is a short psalm of trust, and it ties closely to the land inheritance you read about yesterday. David uses the language of boundary lines and allotments, but he applies it to God himself. Notice the shift in the last verses to the hope of life beyond death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 16 is a "miktam" of David, a psalm of quiet confidence. It sits well with the reading in Joshua. After surveying tribal allotments and the Levites' inheritance in the LORD himself, we find David using the same language: "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup." The psalm also has a surprising ending. Peter quotes it on the day of Pentecost as a prophecy of the resurrection of Christ (Acts 2:25-31), and Paul does the same in Acts 13. So it is a psalm of David's own trust in God, and also a psalm that points beyond David to the Messiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David prays, "Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge" (v. 1).
2. "I have no good apart from you" (v. 2).
3. He delights in the saints in the land, "the excellent ones" (v. 3).
4. Those who choose another god multiply their sorrows (v. 4).
5. "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot" (v. 5).
6. "The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance" (v. 6).

7. “I have set the LORD always before me; because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken” (v. 8).
8. “You will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption” (v. 10).
9. “In your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 16 is a profession of contentment. David has examined his life, and he discovers that everything good in it comes from God. “I have no good apart from you.” That is the first big claim. He then applies the language of the land to the Lord himself: “The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot.” A “portion” is a share of an inheritance, a “cup” is what one is given to drink, and a “lot” is the allotment of land. David uses exactly the vocabulary of the chapters you just read in Joshua, and he applies it to God. God is not only the giver of the inheritance. He is the inheritance.

The effect is a settled gladness. “The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places.” It is the speech of someone who has stopped comparing his portion with others. He looks at what God has given, and he says it is beautiful. This is the opposite of covetousness. Those who run after other gods multiply their sorrows, because they chase a portion that cannot satisfy.

David also has a practice. “I have set the LORD always before me.” The posture is a conscious habit of living with God in view. And the result is stability: “Because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken.” A person who keeps God before his eyes finds that circumstances lose some of their power.

Then the psalm turns upward. “My flesh also dwells secure. For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.” David is confident that death will not have the last word. Peter explains in Acts 2 that David could not be speaking only of himself, for David died and his tomb is still known. He was speaking as a prophet of the resurrection of Christ, “the Holy One,” who did not see corruption. Jesus is the one for whom this psalm is perfectly true. His body was laid in a tomb, but it did not decay. And because he rose, those who are in him share the promise of verse 11: “You make known to me the path of life; in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore.”

STEP 5

Connection

The language of portion and lot draws on Numbers 18:20 and Joshua 13-19. Peter quotes verses 8-11 in Acts 2:25-28, and Paul quotes verse 10 in Acts 13:35. Psalm 73:25-26 expresses a similar delight in God as portion. The path of life recalls Proverbs 4 and Matthew 7:13-14, and

the “fullness of joy” anticipates Revelation 21:3-4.

STEP 6

Application

Test your contentment. Where are you tempted to say, “If only I had…”? Pray through Psalm 16:5-6 and ask the Lord to make you glad in the portion he has given.

Practice setting the LORD before you. Choose one moment in each day, such as your commute or your lunch break, to pause and pray, “Lord, you are here.” See whether it changes how you handle that part of the day.

And give thanks for the resurrection. Because Christ was not abandoned to the grave, your own death will not be an abandonment either.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what it means that he is your chosen portion.
- Ask him to teach you contentment in him and to keep him always before you.
- Thank him for Christ’s resurrection and the hope it gives you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 210 · WEEK 30

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you followed Israel through Jericho, Ai, Gibeon, and the northern campaign, and you read the long lists of tribal allotments. Today, rest in the one thing all these chapters point to: God himself is the inheritance of his people. If you have time, reread Psalm 16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

REST

Meditation

Psalm 16:5-6 takes the dry geography of this week's reading and turns it into worship.

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup." The Levites received no land, and the text said, "the LORD is their inheritance." David says the same of himself, and the New Testament says it of every believer. If you are in Christ, you have been given God. Not just his gifts, or his help, but himself.

"You hold my lot." A lot is something cast, and what falls is out of your hands. But David says that God holds it. Your circumstances, your family, your calling, and your seasons are not random. They are in the hand of one who loves you.

“The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places.” The boundary lines in Joshua were measured with cords. David looks at the lines of his life and calls them pleasant. This does not mean everything is easy. It means that the gift of God himself outweighs any other loss.

“Indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.” This is a statement of gratitude. Say the verse aloud. Notice what you are tempted to compare. Then let the verse reorient you toward the one who holds you. Christ is the heir of all things, and in him you are a co-heir.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw what a faithful God does with a faithful people. You listened to the music of Psalm 66, which called you to shout for joy and recalled God’s testing. You watched Jericho fall without a siege and Israel stumble at Ai because of Achan’s hidden sin. You watched Joshua make a hasty treaty with Gibeon and see the sun stand still. You followed the northern campaign and the list of defeated kings, and then read the first of the great land allotments, with Caleb asking for his mountain at eighty-five and the daughters of Zelophehad claiming their inheritance. And you sang Psalm 16, where David calls the LORD his portion and his cup.

The week held two truths together: God is holy and judges sin, and he is also faithful and gives his people an inheritance.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where is God calling you to trust his power instead of your own resources? Jericho fell by faith and obedience, and Ai fell after sin was dealt with. Think about a situation you are tempted to handle by effort alone. What would it look like to pray first, and then obey?

How does Jesus fulfill what Joshua only began? Joshua led Israel into a land, but the land was partial and was lost. Jesus, whose name means the same thing, leads his people into a better inheritance that cannot fade. How does Hebrews 4:8-9 or Psalm 16:10-11 help you see the difference? What does it mean to you that the inheritance is secured by Christ’s resurrection?

What are you tempted to count as your portion apart from God? Money, status, comfort, relationships, or reputation can all quietly become what we live for. Name one and ask the Lord to teach you to say, “You are my portion.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is your portion and that your lines have fallen in pleasant places.

Thank Jesus, the true Joshua, for winning an inheritance you could never earn.

Rest in him today.

DAY 211 · WEEK 31

Psalm 23

The LORD is my shepherd, rest and restoration

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 23. It is probably the most familiar psalm in the Bible, so read it as if for the first time. Slow down at each line. Notice the change from third person (“he”) to second person (“you”) in the middle of verse 4, as the psalm moves from talking about the shepherd to talking to him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 23 comes at the beginning of this week as a reflection on the rest God gives. Israel is settling into the land, and the shepherd imagery of this psalm captures what the land of promise is meant to be: a place of green pastures and still waters under the care of a good shepherd. David, who wrote this psalm, was himself a shepherd boy before he was a king, so he knew what a shepherd’s work involved. He uses it to describe the LORD’s care. This psalm is often read at funerals, but it is a psalm for the living as much as for the dying. It is about what it means to lack nothing because of who God is.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want” (v. 1).
2. He makes me lie down in green pastures and leads me beside still waters (v. 2).
3. “He restores my soul. He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name’s sake” (v. 3).
4. “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me” (v. 4).
5. The shepherd’s “rod and staff” comfort me (v. 4).

6. “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows” (v. 5).
7. “Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life” (v. 6).
8. “I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening line carries the whole psalm. “The LORD is my shepherd.” Everything that follows is an unpacking of what it means. “I shall not want” does not mean “I will get everything I desire.” It means “I will lack nothing I truly need, because I belong to him.” A shepherd takes responsibility for his sheep. He finds food, water, rest, and safety. Sheep can do none of this for themselves. They are among the most dependent animals, and David says that is a good thing, because the one who looks after us is the LORD.

Verses 2-3 describe the shepherd’s gentle care: green pastures, still waters, a restored soul. These are images of rest, a theme that fits the week well. The shepherd leads. The sheep follow. Note that the paths are “paths of righteousness for his name’s sake.” The shepherd guides his flock in the right way, and his reputation is tied to it. He will not lose those he has promised to keep.

Then comes the valley. David does not claim that the good shepherd leads only through pleasant places. There is a valley of deep darkness, and it is on the path. But look at what changes there. The language shifts in the middle of verse 4 from “he” to “you.” In the dark, David stops talking about God and starts talking to him. “You are with me.” That is the heart of the psalm. The comfort is not an absence of danger but the presence of the shepherd. His rod defends against predators, and his staff guides and rescues. The same tools that protect also comfort.

Verse 5 changes the metaphor from a shepherd to a host. The table is set “in the presence of my enemies.” God’s hospitality is not hidden from those who oppose us. He anoints and fills. The cup overflows. This is the language of extravagant welcome.

The last verse promises that goodness and mercy will pursue David, not just follow. The Hebrew verb is “chase.” All his days, God’s kindness is on his heels. And the final destination is the house of the LORD forever.

For Christians, the shepherd has a name. Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep” (John 10:11). The psalm takes on its fullest meaning in him. He walked through the valley of death himself, so that when we pass through it, we find him already there.

STEP 5

Connection

The shepherd image is used of God in Genesis 48:15 and 49:24, and of Israel's leaders in Ezekiel 34, where God promises to shepherd his people himself. Jesus claims the title in John 10:1-18, and Hebrews 13:20 calls him "the great shepherd of the sheep." The table before enemies recalls the covenant meals of Exodus 24 and anticipates the Lord's Supper. Revelation 7:17 says the Lamb "will be their shepherd."

STEP 6

Application

Read this psalm aloud once today, slowly. Then tell the Lord one area of your life where you have been behaving like a sheep who thinks it must provide for itself. Hand it over.

If you are in a valley right now, notice the pronoun change. Try praying the second half of verse 4 in your own words: "You are with me." Say it out loud.

If you are in a season of green pastures, receive them with thanks. Don't rush past rest. Ask the Lord what he might be restoring in you.

Finally, ask who you could shepherd this week. A friend, a child, or a younger believer may need your presence. We carry the shepherd's care to others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell the Lord what you lack, and what you need him to shepherd.
- Ask him to restore your soul, and to remind you he is with you in the dark valley.
- Thank Jesus, the good shepherd.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 212 · WEEK 31

Joshua 18:1-19:51

The remaining tribal allotments, every tribe has a place

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 18:1-19:51. These chapters finish the distribution of the land. They begin with a gentle rebuke from Joshua, then describe how the remaining seven tribes receive their portions. Read for the shape of the story: the tabernacle is set up at Shiloh, and every tribe gets a place. Notice the last allotment, Joshua's own.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has taken much of the land, but seven tribes have not yet received their inheritance. The tabernacle has been set up at Shiloh, and the people seem to have settled into a comfortable pause. Joshua asks a sharp question: "How long will you put off going in to take possession of the land?" The solution is a survey. Three men from each tribe are sent out to write a description of the land in seven parts, and Joshua casts lots before the LORD at Shiloh to divide it. The chapter is, in a way, about the danger of delay. God has given the land. The question is whether the people will go and take it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The whole congregation assembles at Shiloh and sets up the tent of meeting there (18:1).
2. "There remained among the people of Israel seven tribes whose inheritance had not yet been apportioned" (18:2).
3. Joshua asks, "How long will you put off going in to take possession of the land, which the LORD, the God of your fathers, has given you?" (18:3).
4. Men are sent to survey the land and write a description in a book (18:4-9).
5. Joshua casts lots for them "before the LORD" (18:10).

6. Benjamin's territory lies between Judah and Joseph and includes Jerusalem (called Jebus) and Gibeon (18:11-28).

7. Simeon's inheritance is taken from within Judah's allotment, "for the portion of the tribe of Judah was too large for them" (19:9).

8. Last of all, Joshua is given the city he asked for, Timnath-serah, "and he rebuilt the city and settled in it" (19:49-50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The tone of chapter 18 is surprising. After the dramatic scenes of Jericho and Ai, the narrator pauses to describe a sluggishness. Seven tribes have not claimed their land, and Joshua asks them why. The question "How long will you put off?" hints at laziness and fear. Some of the territory remained uncleared, and it may have seemed easier to stay at Shiloh near the tabernacle than to go out and face the Canaanites.

This is a familiar spiritual pattern. After a high season of obedience, we can drift into passivity. We feel that God has done enough, and we hesitate to claim what he has given. The promise has been made, but possessing the promise requires effort. Joshua's answer is not a rousing speech. It is a practical plan. He asks the tribes to choose surveyors, write down what they see, and bring it back. The act of describing the land makes the abstract concrete. Sometimes the first step to obedience is simply to look clearly at what God has set before us and write it down.

Then lots are cast "before the LORD" at Shiloh. The use of lots in the Old Testament expressed trust that God, not human cleverness or favoritism, determined the outcome (Proverbs 16:33). The allotments fit each tribe's size and were set by the sovereign God. No tribe was forgotten, and none was able to claim a better deal by pulling strings. Each could say, "This is what the LORD gave me."

The details of Benjamin's land hold a hint of the future. It includes Jerusalem, which will be the city of David and the temple, and Gibeon, where the tabernacle will later rest. Simeon receives land inside Judah, which is a gentle fulfillment of Jacob's prophecy in Genesis 49:7, that Simeon would be scattered in Israel.

The chapter ends with Joshua. The leader of Israel is the last to receive his portion, and he asks for a modest town in the hill country of Ephraim. He has served everyone else first. It is a quiet picture of humble leadership, and it echoes the pattern of the one who came "not to be served but to serve." Joshua's rebuilt city is a small sign that, in Christ, the servant is rewarded with rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Shiloh becomes the center of Israel's worship in Judges and 1 Samuel. The use of lots recalls Numbers 26:55 and Proverbs 16:33. Jacob's words on Simeon are in Genesis 49:5-7. The delay in possessing the promise parallels the call in Hebrews 4:11 to "strive to enter that rest" and anticipates 2 Peter 1:5-10. Joshua's service as the last to receive anticipates Mark 10:45.

STEP 6

Application

Is there an area where God has already given you something and you are still waiting at "Shiloh"? It might be a calling, a gift, a relationship, or a spiritual discipline. Ask yourself, "How long will I put off taking it?" Choose one small first step this week.

Try Joshua's method: look at it clearly, write it down, and make a plan. If you feel a sense of calling but no action, write a one-page description of what it would look like to pursue it.

Remember also that you have been given a portion. You do not need to compare it with anyone else's. Thank God for the specific place and work he has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have delayed or been passive in taking what God has given.
- Ask him to show you what he has already given you.
- Ask him for the courage to take hold of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 213 · WEEK 31

Joshua 20:1-22:34

Cities of refuge; Levitical cities; the eastern tribes' altar

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 20:1-22:34. Three episodes fill these chapters: the cities of refuge, the cities given to the Levites, and the near-disaster of the altar built by the eastern tribes. Read the cities of refuge with Hebrews 6:18 in mind, and read the altar story as a lesson in how God's people handle misunderstanding.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The land has been divided, and there are some important administrative matters left. God had commanded Moses to set up cities of refuge, places where someone who had killed another person accidentally could flee for protection from the avenger of blood. The Levites, who received no tribal territory, are given towns and pasturelands. And then the eastern tribes, Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh, who had helped the others conquer the land, are sent home. On the way, they build a large altar by the Jordan, and the rest of Israel prepares for civil war. The chapters show a nation learning to live in the land under God's law, and the dangers of misunderstanding within the covenant family.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Joshua to "appoint the cities of refuge, of which I spoke to you through Moses" (20:2).
2. A person who killed "without intent" could flee to a city of refuge and stand before the elders at the gate (20:3-6).
3. The six cities are spread across the land, three on each side of the Jordan (20:7-9).
4. The man could stay there until the death of the high priest who was in office at the time (20:6).

5. Forty-eight cities with pasturelands are given to the Levites (21:1-42).
6. "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass" (21:45).
7. The eastern tribes build "an altar of imposing size" by the Jordan, and the western tribes gather at Shiloh "to go up against them in war" (22:10-12).
8. Phinehas leads a delegation, and the eastern tribes explain that the altar is a witness, not a place for sacrifice (22:21-29, 34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The cities of refuge are an expression of both justice and mercy. The law required that a murderer be put to death, but it also recognized that not every killing is murder. If someone killed another by accident, the avenger of blood could still pursue him, and the refuge was there to protect him. The elders of the city would hear his case, and he would be shielded until a proper trial. And the release came with the death of the high priest. This is one of the most interesting details in the whole system. The high priest's death brings freedom for those who are confined. The author of Hebrews uses this kind of reasoning, because the death of our great high priest gives freedom to all who have fled to him for refuge. The six cities were also placed so that no one was too far from one. In Christ, the refuge is always near.

The Levite cities show God's care for those who serve him. They do not hold a block of land, but they live among every tribe, as teachers and priests, so that the whole nation would be reached. The summary in 21:43-45 is among the most important statements in the book. "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass." The narrator pauses to record God's faithfulness. It is a statement that is both historic and prophetic, since the story of Judges will immediately show the tragic ways Israel fails. But God does not fail.

Chapter 22 is a drama of near catastrophe. The eastern tribes erect an altar, and the western tribes assume it is rebellion. They are ready to go to war, and they cite Peor and Achan as precedents. But first they send a delegation, led by Phinehas, who is a priest and the zealous son of Eleazar. The meeting is a model of conflict resolution. The delegates come with questions and with a genuine concern for the covenant. The eastern tribes reply by explaining their motive. They had feared that future generations of western Israel would say, "You have no portion in the LORD." The altar was built as a witness that they too belong to Israel. Phinehas and the leaders are satisfied, and the potential war is replaced by a blessing. The altar is named "Witness."

The lesson is twofold. Zeal for God must be married to listening. And the unity of God's people depends on honest communication. Division is often the result of assumptions. Many church conflicts could be avoided if believers followed the pattern of Phinehas, who went and asked before acting.

STEP 5

Connection

The law of refuge appears in Numbers 35 and Deuteronomy 19. Hebrews 6:18 speaks of those who "have fled for refuge" to lay hold of the hope in Christ. The Levite cities fulfill Numbers 35:1-8. Joshua 21:45 is echoed in 23:14 and 1 Kings 8:56. The earlier eastern tribes' agreement is in Numbers 32. The reference to Peor and Achan recalls Numbers 25 and Joshua 7. Matthew 18:15-20 gives a New Testament pattern for dealing with conflict.

STEP 6

Application

First, take refuge. If you feel guilt or fear, remember that Christ is a city of refuge for those who run to him. Take a specific burden to him today and rest there.

Second, consider whom you might be misjudging. Is there a person or a group you have assumed the worst about? Before acting, follow Phinehas: go and ask. Choose one relationship where a direct and gracious conversation could clear the air.

Third, receive the testimony of verse 45. Write it on a card: "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made… had failed." Read it when you are tempted to doubt.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Run to Christ with your guilt, and tell him what it is.
- Ask him to make you quick to ask before you accuse.
- Thank him for being your city of refuge.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 214 · WEEK 31

Joshua 23:1-24:33

Joshua's farewell; covenant renewal, choose this day

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 23:1-24:33. The book closes with two farewell speeches and a covenant ceremony. Read chapter 23 as an old man's pastoral warning, and chapter 24 as one of the great covenant renewals in the Bible. Note the question at the center: "Choose this day whom you will serve."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joshua is old, and he knows he will die soon. Like Moses before him, he gathers Israel to give them final instructions. The first speech, in chapter 23, is to the leaders. It is a mixture of reminder and warning. The second, in chapter 24, takes place at Shechem, the place where God first gave Abraham the promise of the land, and where Israel had pronounced the blessings and curses. Joshua retells the story from Abraham to the present and then calls the people to a decision. This is the book's climax, and it explains what everything has been for. God has kept his promises. Will his people keep faith with him?

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joshua says, "You have seen all that the LORD your God has done… for it is the LORD your God who has fought for you" (23:3).
2. "Be very strong to keep and to do all that is written in the Book of the Law of Moses" (23:6).
3. He warns against intermarrying with the nations and serving their gods, for "they shall be a snare and a trap for you" (23:12-13).
4. At Shechem, Joshua recounts the history from Terah and Abraham, who "served other gods" beyond the River, up to the conquest (24:2-13).

5. “Now therefore fear the LORD and serve him in sincerity and in faithfulness. Put away the gods that your fathers served” (24:14).
6. “Choose this day whom you will serve… But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD” (24:15).
7. The people say, “Far be it from us that we should forsake the LORD,” and Joshua replies, “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God” (24:16-19).
8. Joshua sets up a stone as a witness, and the book ends with the burials of Joshua, Joseph’s bones, and Eleazar (24:26-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Joshua’s farewell has the weight of a last testament. He reminds the leaders that the victories were God’s: “it is the LORD your God who has fought for you.” Then he issues a conditional warning. If they cling to the LORD, the nations will be driven out. If they turn aside and join the nations, they will be a snare and a trap, and they will perish from the good land. The word “if” is a reminder that enjoying the inheritance requires faithfulness. The relationship is a covenant, and covenants have promises and responsibilities.

The scene at Shechem is the great moment. Joshua recites the history of salvation: God took Abraham from idolatrous Mesopotamia, gave him a family, delivered them from Egypt, defeated the Amorites, and gave them a land they did not labor for and cities they did not build. It is a summary of grace. Everything the people have is a gift. Then the “therefore” comes. Because God has done all this, fear him and serve him. Obedience in the Bible is always a response to grace.

Then the famous verse. “Choose this day whom you will serve.” It is not a neutral invitation. Joshua presents the options bluntly: the gods beyond the river, the gods of the Amorites, or the LORD. There is no fourth option of serving no one. Everyone worships something. Then he gives his own testimony: “But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.” The decision is personal and also household-wide. A leader’s faith carries weight in his family.

The people respond confidently, but Joshua’s next statement is startling: “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God.” This is not discouragement but realism. The people are overconfident. They think they can serve God by their own resolution. Joshua knows that a holy God demands more than good intentions. The law cannot make anyone holy. This is the very question the New Testament will answer. God provides in Christ what the law demanded, and by his Spirit he writes the law on our hearts. We are not able. He is.

The covenant is renewed with a stone as witness. The book ends with burials, a note of closure. Joseph's bones, carried from Egypt for four hundred years, are finally laid to rest at Shechem. The promise made to him in Genesis 50:25 has been kept. And Joshua dies, called "the servant of the LORD," a title previously given only to Moses. The next book will show what happens when the leader is gone.

STEP 5

Connection

Joshua 24 echoes the covenant formats of Deuteronomy and the ancient suzerainty treaties. The history from Abraham to the conquest summarizes Genesis through Joshua. The burial of Joseph's bones fulfills Genesis 50:24-25 and Exodus 13:19. The warning about intermarriage recalls Deuteronomy 7:1-4. The inability to serve a holy God anticipates Romans 8:3, Hebrews 10, and Jeremiah 31. Jesus quotes the spirit of this choice in Matthew 6:24, "You cannot serve God and money."

STEP 6

Application

Take Joshua's question seriously: whom are you serving? Not in theory, but in practice. Look at where your time, money, and attention flow. Is there a "god" that has quietly taken a throne in your heart? Name it, and renounce it.

Make the household decision. If you have a spouse, children, or roommates, ask what "as for me and my house" might look like in practice: a shared meal and a prayer, a habit of reading Scripture together, a commitment to a church.

Finally, receive the sober words of verse 19. You are not able to serve God in your own strength. Say that honestly to him, and then rely on the Spirit and on Christ's righteousness to be what you cannot be on your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you choose today, and who you want to serve with.
- Ask him to show you any idols you still keep and to give strength to put them away.
- Pray for your household or those closest to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 215 · WEEK 31

Judges 1:1-3:31

Incomplete conquest; the cycle begins; the first judges

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 1:1-3:31. This is the longest reading of the week, and it introduces a new era. Notice how the book begins by mirroring Joshua, then slowly shows decline. Pay special attention to 2:6-3:6, which gives the key to the whole book, and to the stories of Othniel, Ehud, and Shamgar.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joshua is dead, and a whole generation passes. The book of Judges tells what happens next. It covers roughly three hundred years, from the death of Joshua to just before the monarchy, and it is a dark and honest account. Israel has the land but not the faithfulness to keep it. The opening chapter reports tribe-by-tribe incomplete conquest. The next chapters explain why: Israel's failure to drive out the nations and its habit of worshiping their gods. The book then introduces a repeating pattern that will shape every story to come. This is the most important thing to grasp as you start Judges. The stories are not about heroes. They are about a people who keep forgetting, and a God who keeps saving.

STEP 3

Observation

1. After Joshua's death, Israel asks the LORD, "Who shall go up first for us against the Canaanites?" and the LORD says Judah (1:1-2).
2. The first chapter lists repeated failures: "did not drive out" appears again and again (1:19, 21, 27-33).
3. The angel of the LORD at Bochim rebukes Israel for making covenants with the inhabitants and not breaking down their altars (2:1-5).

4. “There arose another generation after them who did not know the LORD or the work that he had done for Israel” (2:10).
5. Israel “did what was evil in the sight of the LORD and served the Baals” (2:11).
6. The pattern: sin, oppression, cry for help, deliverance by a judge, rest, then relapse (2:11-19).
7. Othniel, Caleb’s nephew, delivers Israel and the land has rest forty years (3:7-11).
8. Ehud, a left-handed Benjaminite, kills the fat king Eglon (3:12-30). Shamgar strikes down six hundred Philistines with an oxgoad (3:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book of Judges opens with an echo and a shadow. The question, “Who shall go up first for us?” mirrors the opening of Joshua, and God’s answer is Judah, just as Genesis 49 would suggest. For a few verses, it seems the conquest will continue. But the language quickly changes. “Did not drive out.” This phrase becomes the drumbeat of the chapter, a quiet record of compromise. The tribes of Benjamin, Manasseh, Ephraim, Zebulun, Asher, Naphtali, and Dan each fail to dislodge the Canaanites. The theme is partial obedience. Israel is not rebelling openly, but it is settling for less than God had commanded.

The angel of the LORD arrives at Bochim, “the weepers,” and gives the reason. Israel had made treaties with the people of the land and left their altars standing. They were warned. The consequences are described: the nations will become thorns and their gods a snare. The people weep, and offer a sacrifice, but there is no real repentance. This will be a pattern.

The center of the section is 2:6-3:6, which is the theological preface to the whole book. The generation of Joshua dies, and another arises that “did not know the LORD or the work that he had done.” This is one of the saddest sentences in the Bible. The faith was not handed down. Joshua had built the memorial stones, but the story was not told. Then the cycle begins. Israel does evil, God gives them into the hands of oppressors, they cry out, and God raises up a judge to save them. But when the judge dies, the people go back, and they do so even worse than their fathers. The pattern is a spiral downward.

It is important to see that the judges are not moral exemplars. They are “saviors” whom God raises up, flawed and often surprising. Othniel is the one clean example, a faithful man from Caleb’s family. Ehud is a trickster who uses his left hand and a hidden blade. Shamgar is a rough farmer with an oxgoad. The point is not their virtue but God’s compassion. Judges 2:18 says, “the LORD was moved to pity by their groaning.” God saves not because Israel deserves it but because he is merciful.

Why does God leave some nations in the land? Judges 2:22 and 3:1-4 say it was to test Israel, to see whether they would keep the way of the LORD, and to teach war to the generations who had not known it. The testing exposes the heart. And it creates a longing. If these saviors are so flawed and the people so fickle, we begin to ask for a better savior and a king who will truly lead. Judges is the book that makes the reader long for Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

The failure to drive out the nations contradicts Deuteronomy 7:1-6 and Joshua 23:12-13. The loss of memory in 2:10 contrasts with Deuteronomy 6:4-9, 20-25. The cycle pattern echoes Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28. Othniel's story ties back to Joshua 15:16-19. The repeated "cry out" and God's pity recall Exodus 2:23-25. The judges anticipate the greater Savior of Luke 1:68-75.

STEP 6

Application

First, consider the failure to pass on the faith. If you have children, grandchildren, or others you are discipling, ask what you are doing to tell them what God has done. Plan one concrete step this week, such as sharing a testimony or reading a psalm together.

Second, examine your own cycle. We all have patterns: sin, consequences, a cry for help, forgiveness, and, too often, a return. Where do you see this? Ask the Lord to help you move from regret to repentance and from repentance to a changed life.

Third, take comfort in God's pity. He was "moved to pity by their groaning." He still is. Bring your groaning to him without hiding it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess partial obedience and a short memory, as you see them in your own heart.
- Ask him to teach you to tell the next generation what he has done.
- Thank him that he is moved to pity by his people's groaning.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 216 · WEEK 31

Judges 4:1-5:31

Deborah and Barak; the song of Deborah

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 4:1-5:31. The reading includes the story of Deborah and Barak in prose (chapter 4) and a poem of victory (chapter 5). Notice the two women, Deborah and Jael, who play central roles in a book that is otherwise dominated by men. Read the Song of Deborah aloud, if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The cycle of Judges continues. After Ehud's rest, Israel again does evil, and God sells them into the hand of Jabin, a king of Canaan who reigns in Hazor, with a commander named Sisera and nine hundred iron chariots. For twenty years he oppresses Israel. Then comes a remarkable judge, Deborah, a prophetess who sits under a palm tree and settles disputes. She summons Barak, and the story that follows is about courage, hesitation, and the surprising ways God works. The poem in chapter 5 is one of the oldest in the Bible. It celebrates the victory and also names who joined the battle and who stayed home.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Deborah is a prophetess and judge who holds court "under the palm of Deborah" in the hill country of Ephraim (4:4-5).
2. She tells Barak that the LORD commands him to gather ten thousand men to Mount Tabor, and promises to give Sisera into his hand (4:6-7).
3. Barak says, "If you will go with me, I will go, but if you will not go with me, I will not go" (4:8).
4. Deborah replies that the honor will go to a woman, and the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman (4:9).

5. “The LORD routed Sisera and all his chariots and all his army” (4:15).
6. Sisera flees on foot to the tent of Jael, wife of Heber the Kenite, who gives him milk, covers him, and drives a tent peg through his temple (4:17-21).
7. The Song of Deborah praises the LORD who “marched from Seir,” and notes that the stars fought from heaven and the river Kishon swept the enemy away (5:4-5, 20-21).
8. The song blesses Jael above women and curses Meroz for not coming to the help of the LORD (5:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Deborah is one of the most striking figures in the book. In a world dominated by male warriors, God raises up a woman as a prophet and judge. She does not lead the army herself, but she delivers the word of the LORD, and her authority is recognized by Barak and the tribes. Her role should remind us that God is not bound by cultural expectations about whom he will use, and that the gifts of prophecy and wisdom come from him.

Barak’s hesitation is also instructive. God has already spoken, and the promise is clear. Yet Barak says he will not go without Deborah. His reluctance is not necessarily cowardice. It may show how much he depends on God’s presence through the prophet. But it costs him. The honor of the final blow will go to a woman. The story then contains a reversal: the conquering general of the iron chariots is brought down by a Kenite woman in a tent.

The battle itself is told briefly. God routs Sisera and his army, and the poem fills in the detail: the stars fought, and the river Kishon swept them away. The text gives the glory to God. The mighty chariots, the Canaanites’ most powerful weapon, are neutralized by a flood. Yet again, God shows that victory does not depend on military strength.

Jael’s act is both shocking and ambiguous. She welcomes a fleeing enemy with hospitality and then kills him in his sleep. The narrator does not condemn or praise her explicitly in chapter 4, but the song in chapter 5 blesses her. She has chosen sides, as an outsider who aligned herself with the people of God. Like Rahab, she is a non-Israelite who joins God’s side. We need not imitate her method. The point is that God uses unexpected people.

The Song of Deborah is a masterwork of praise. It begins with the LORD marching from Seir, a reminder of Sinai, and credits God with the whole victory. It lists the tribes who volunteered and those who stayed behind. Reuben “had great searchings of heart” but remained among the sheepfolds. Meroz is cursed for not coming “to the help of the LORD.” The song shows that the people of God are summoned to take part in his work, and neutrality is not an option.

The final line of the song is a prayer: “So may all your enemies perish, O LORD! But your friends be like the sun as he rises in his might.” The victory of God’s people is a picture of the final victory of Christ, the true seed of the woman who crushes the head of the serpent (Genesis 3:15). Sisera’s death by a woman’s hand is a small echo of that promise.

STEP 5

Connection

The defeat of Jabin and Hazor recalls Joshua 11. The Song of Deborah parallels the Song of Moses (Exodus 15) and Hannah’s song (1 Samuel 2). The imagery of the LORD marching from Seir is also in Deuteronomy 33:2 and Habakkuk 3:3-6. The crushing of the head echoes Genesis 3:15, and Mary’s Magnificat in Luke 1:46-55 follows the same pattern of reversal. Jael is mentioned in Judges 5 as “most blessed of women,” a phrase later applied to Mary in Luke 1:42.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about the ways you hesitate to obey. Like Barak, we may say yes to God, but only if some condition is met. Ask yourself whether you are waiting for something God has not promised before you obey.

Second, be willing to take part. The song blesses those who came and warns those who stayed behind. Is there a need in your church that you have been standing back from? Offer your time or talent in one specific way.

Third, learn from Deborah. She exercised her gift without apology and gave God the glory. Whatever your gifting, use it in service.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he uses unexpected people.
- Confess where you have hesitated to obey him.
- Ask him to help you join his work today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 217 · WEEK 31

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the book of Joshua and began Judges. You read about the land being divided, the cities of refuge, and Joshua's farewell, and then you watched the nation begin to unravel. Take a moment today to hold both together: a God who never fails, and a people who often do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

REST

Meditation

Joshua 21:45 is the hinge between two books. It closes the story of Joshua with a statement of God's perfect faithfulness, and it throws a bright light on the sadness of Judges that follows.

"Not one word." Not most, not nearly all. The promises made to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and renewed to Moses and Joshua, had been kept in full. After centuries of slavery, wandering, and war, the record says nothing has failed.

"Of all the good promises." The word "good" reminds us that God's promises are not threats. They are gifts. He promised a land, rest, victory, and presence, and he gave them.

"That the LORD had made to the house of Israel." The promises were made to a people, and they were kept for a people. They were also kept for the world, because through this people came the Messiah.

“All came to pass.” The statement is complete. Whatever Israel did or did not do, the LORD was faithful.

This verse will be tested immediately by Judges, where Israel is unfaithful and suffers for it. But God does not fail even then. Paul’s words in 2 Corinthians 1:20 make the point: “All the promises of God find their Yes in him.” Every promise God has made is secured in Christ. Carry this verse into the week. When you wonder whether God will keep his word to you, remember that he has never failed.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through a long arc. You sang Psalm 23 and rested in the shepherd. You read the remaining tribal allotments and Joshua’s rebuke to those who delayed possessing the land. You studied the cities of refuge, the cities of the Levites, and the near-war over the altar by the Jordan, and you saw how Phinehas resolved it by asking first. You read Joshua’s farewell at Shechem, with its great challenge, “Choose this day whom you will serve,” and the sober reminder that no one is able to serve a holy God in his own strength. Then you opened Judges. You saw the incomplete conquest, the generation that did not know the LORD, and the repeating cycle of sin and rescue. You met Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, and then Deborah, Barak, and Jael, and heard the song of victory.

The week held a sharp contrast: God’s faithfulness is complete, and his people’s faithfulness is not.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is your “Shiloh”? Joshua asked the tribes how long they would put off taking what God had given. Is there something you have been waiting on, such as a step of obedience, a conversation, a calling, or a discipline? What is the first small step, and when will you take it?

How does Joshua’s statement, “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God,” point you to Jesus? The people were confident they could keep the covenant, and they could not. Christ kept it perfectly on our behalf, and he gives his Spirit to write the law on our hearts. What changes for you when you stop trying to serve God in your own strength and start from what Christ has done?

Whom are you passing the faith on to? Judges 2:10 describes a generation that "did not know the LORD or the work that he had done." Think of one younger person in your life, such as a child, a niece, a friend, or a fellow church member. What is one story of God's faithfulness you could tell them this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that not one of his promises has failed.

Thank Christ in whom every promise is yes.

Confess any distrust, and rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 218 · WEEK 32

Psalm 46

God is our refuge and strength

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 46 aloud. It is a psalm of the Sons of Korah, and it was the inspiration for Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress." Read it three times: first for the images of chaos, second for the images of the city of God, and third for the repeated refrain, "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the sobering opening of Judges, with its picture of a nation in decline, this psalm opens the week with a different note. It is about security in the middle of chaos. The psalm sets the shaking of the earth, the roaring of the seas, and the raging of nations against one unshakable fact: God is with his people. It was likely sung in Jerusalem, perhaps after a deliverance such as Sennacherib's defeat. Whatever its original setting, it makes a powerful companion to the book of Judges, where God's people were constantly in crisis and God was constantly their refuge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea" (v. 2).
3. The waters "roar and foam" and the mountains "tremble at its swelling" (v. 3).
4. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High" (v. 4).
5. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).

6. “The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts” (v. 6).
7. The refrain: “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress” (vv. 7, 11).
8. “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a bold claim: God is not just a refuge from trouble but a “very present help in trouble.” The Hebrew phrase suggests that he is readily found. You do not have to search for him. In the moment of crisis, he is there. The consequence follows at once: “Therefore we will not fear.” Fear is not removed by changing circumstances but by a deeper fact.

The first stanza uses the language of cosmic catastrophe. Mountains fall into the sea, and waters roar. In the ancient world, the sea was the symbol of chaos, and the mountains were the symbol of stability. The psalm imagines both of these being undone. If anything could shake a believer, it would be this. Yet the declaration is, “we will not fear.” The point is not that disasters never come, but that they cannot unseat the God who is present with us.

The second stanza turns to the city of God. There is a river whose streams make it glad. This is striking, because Jerusalem had no river. The psalm is describing something spiritual: the presence of God is the river that nourishes his people. It echoes Eden’s river in Genesis 2 and anticipates the river of the water of life in Revelation 22. In the midst of this city, God dwells. “She shall not be moved.” While the mountains shake, the city stays secure, because God is in her.

The third stanza shifts to the nations and the end of war. The LORD speaks, and the earth melts. He breaks the bow and burns the chariots. The psalm ends with a call: “Be still, and know that I am God.” This is not a gentle invitation to quiet meditation, though it can include that. In context, it is a command to the raging nations to cease their fighting. “Be still” means “stop” or “let go.” But it is also a word to God’s people. When we are anxious, we are told to cease striving and acknowledge God’s rule. The knowledge of God’s sovereignty is the antidote to panic.

The refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress,” ties together the great and the small. He is the commander of heaven’s armies, and he is the God of Jacob, the God who chose a flawed man and bound himself to him. This is the God who stands with Israel in the book of Judges, and with the church today. His name for us in the New Testament is Immanuel, “God with us.”

STEP 5

Connection

The river echoes Genesis 2:10, Ezekiel 47, and Revelation 22:1-2. The deliverance of Jerusalem recalls Isaiah 36-37. The breaking of the bow is also promised in Hosea 2:18 and Zechariah 9:10. “The LORD of hosts is with us” prepares for Isaiah 7:14 and Matthew 1:23, “Immanuel.” Jesus stills the storm in Mark 4:35-41, which shows that he is the God of this psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one area where fear has taken hold. Perhaps it is health, work, a family concern, or the news. Read verses 1-3 and say, “Therefore I will not fear.” Then speak the refrain aloud.

Practice stillness. Set a timer for five minutes today, and in silence, simply repeat “Be still, and know that I am God.” Notice what you are tempted to do instead.

Finally, praise God for his presence in the church. The city of God is not shaken, even when its members are. Thank him for the community he has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are afraid of, and speak Psalm 46:1 over it.
- Ask him to quiet your striving and teach you to be still.
- Thank him that in Christ he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 219 · WEEK 32

Psalm 76

In Judah God is known, the God who breaks bows

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 76. It is a short song of victory that celebrates God's defeat of his enemies in Jerusalem. It is thought to be connected to the deliverance of the city from Sennacherib, and it ties naturally with Psalm 46. Notice the movement from God's dwelling place to his judgment of the earth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A psalm of Asaph, Psalm 76 sits alongside Psalm 46 as a song of Zion. Both celebrate God's protection of his city and his power over the nations. This psalm is slightly different, though. It concentrates on the character of God as a warrior and a judge. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel." It is a reminder that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity but the one who breaks weapons and brings kings low. For a church reading Judges, it is a statement that no oppressor, no matter how strong, can ultimately withstand him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel" (v. 1).
2. "His abode has been established in Salem, his dwelling place in Zion" (v. 2).
3. "There he broke the flashing arrows, the shield, the sword, and the weapons of war" (v. 3).
4. God is "more majestic than the mountains full of prey" (v. 4).
5. "The stouthearted were stripped of their spoil; they sank into sleep; all the men of war were unable to use their hands" (v. 5).
6. "At your rebuke, O God of Jacob, both rider and horse lay stunned" (v. 6).

7. “You, you are to be feared! Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” (v. 7).

8. “You make the earth afraid and still, when God arose to establish judgment, to save all the humble of the earth” (vv. 8-9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 76 sings of a victory that no one on Israel’s side won. The weapons were broken. The warriors slept. The horse and rider lay stunned. There is little mention of Israel’s army, because the victory was God’s. The theme of divine warfare, which you saw throughout Joshua and Judges, is here turned into worship.

Notice the first verse. “In Judah God is known.” This is not just a statement of geography but a statement of revelation. God has made himself known in a particular people and a particular place. His dwelling in Salem, which is Jerusalem, was the center of Israel’s worship. It recalls Melchizedek, the priest-king of Salem in Genesis 14, whom you read about earlier. The city that would hold the temple was already associated with that mysterious priest.

The psalm’s depiction of God is both terrifying and comforting. He is “more majestic than the mountains full of prey.” This image suggests that all earthly powers, the predators of the world, are small compared to him. He is to be feared. “Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” The answer is no one. But the psalm’s purpose in saying this is salvation. Verse 9 says God arose to establish judgment “to save all the humble of the earth.” The anger that terrifies the proud is the same power that rescues the humble. For those who trust him, his might is a shelter.

The final stanza makes a surprising turn. Even the wrath of man shall praise him. God uses the rage of his enemies to display his glory, and what is left over he restrains. This is a sweeping statement of divine sovereignty. Even the wickedness of the wicked ends up serving the purposes of God. The cross is the ultimate example: the wrath of men against Christ was the means of salvation.

The psalm ends with a call to action. “Make your vows to the LORD your God and perform them.” Because God is the victorious judge, his people are to respond with worship and fidelity. And all around him are to bring gifts to “him who is to be feared.” The psalm has moved from the mountains to the nations to the lives of individual worshipers.

STEP 5

Connection

Salem links to Genesis 14:18 and Hebrews 7:1-2. Both Psalm 46 and Psalm 76 reflect the deliverance in Isaiah 37. The idea that God uses human wrath for his glory is seen in Genesis 50:20, Exodus 9:16, and Acts 4:27-28. The promise to save "the humble of the earth" echoes Psalm 37:11 and Matthew 5:5. Revelation 19 shows the final victory of the Lord over the nations.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whom you fear. If you are anxious about powerful people, institutions, or circumstances, read verse 7 aloud. The one who can stand before God is no one. And the one who trusts him need not fear anyone else.

Make a vow and keep it. The psalm ends with a call to fulfill vows to God. Think of a commitment you have made to him or to others, such as a promise to pray, to serve, or to give. Renew it and take one practical step.

Finally, trust that God can use even hostility for good. If you are facing opposition, ask him to bring praise from it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Stand in awe of God's majesty, in your own words.
- Ask him to keep you from fearing anyone but him.
- Thank him that he saves the humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 220 · WEEK 32

Judges 6:1-8:35

Gideon called; the fleece; the 300; victory and aftermath

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 98 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 6:1-8:35. This is a long reading, so read it in three movements: Gideon's call and the fleece (chapter 6), the victory with three hundred men (chapter 7), and the aftermath (chapter 8). Keep in mind the verse that stands behind the story: "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has again done evil, and this time the Midianites oppress them so severely that the people hide in caves and mountain strongholds. Every harvest is stripped by swarms of raiders "like locusts." Into this misery God sends a prophet to remind Israel why they are suffering, and then he sends an angel to a farmer named Gideon, who is threshing wheat in a winepress to hide it from the Midianites. Gideon is not the obvious choice for a hero. The stories that follow show a man who is hesitant, who tests God, and who triumphs only because God shrinks his army to nothing. But they also show how quickly a victory can become a snare.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The angel of the LORD greets Gideon, "The LORD is with you, O mighty man of valor" (6:12), while Gideon is hiding.
2. Gideon objects, "My clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the least in my father's house" (6:15).
3. He tears down his father's altar of Baal and Asherah by night, and is nicknamed Jerubbaal (6:25-32).

4. Gideon asks for a sign with the fleece, first wet with dew while the ground is dry, then the reverse (6:36-40).
5. God reduces the army from 32,000 to 10,000 to 300, “lest Israel boast over me” (7:2-8).
6. The 300 carry trumpets, empty jars, and torches, and shout, “For the LORD and for Gideon!” (7:16-20).
7. The Ephraimites complain that they were not called sooner, and Gideon soothes them with a gentle answer (8:1-3).
8. Gideon refuses the kingship but makes an ephod from the gold, which “became a snare to Gideon and to his house” (8:22-27).
9. After the victory, the land has rest for forty years, but when Gideon dies Israel again goes after the Baals (8:28-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The angel’s greeting is deliberately ironic. “The LORD is with you, O mighty man of valor.” Gideon is at the winepress, hiding. God speaks to who he will make him, not who he is now. This is a pattern in the Bible: God sees what he will do through the person, not just their present weakness. Gideon’s response is one of honest objection. “If the LORD is with us, why then has all this happened to us?” It is a real question, and God does not scold him for it. Instead, God answers with a promise: “I will be with you.”

Before Gideon can defeat the Midianites, he must deal with idolatry at home. God tells him to tear down his father’s altar to Baal, and Gideon does it at night, afraid of the people. It is a small act of faith with big consequences. The first battle is always internal. We cannot expect God to defeat our enemies while we shelter our idols.

The fleece story is often misread as a model for guidance. In fact, Gideon had already received a clear word from God, and the fleece shows his unbelief. Still, God graciously answers. The lesson is not that we should seek signs, but that God is patient with weak faith. The better way is to trust his word without needing proof.

The reduction of the army is the center of the story. God says that 32,000 is too many “lest Israel boast over me, saying, ‘My own hand has saved me.’” Twenty-two thousand leave out of fear, and the remaining 10,000 are reduced to 300 by their way of drinking water. The strategy makes the victory unmistakable. Three hundred men with trumpets, jars, and torches defeat a host “like locusts in abundance.” The point is not the cleverness of the plan but its absurdity. God’s power is made perfect in weakness, as Paul will say in 2 Corinthians 12:9.

But the story does not end in triumph. In chapter 8, Gideon deals with Ephraim wisely, but takes brutal revenge on the towns that refused him supplies. He refuses the crown with the right words, "The LORD will rule over you," but then asks for gold and makes an ephod. The ephod becomes an idol, and "all Israel whored after it there." The man who tore down Baal's altar ends by building a rival object of worship. Even the best of the judges fail. The people forget God as soon as Gideon dies. The tragedy shows that Israel's problem is not just a lack of leaders but a hardness of heart. It is a heart problem that no judge can fix.

STEP 5

Connection

The call of Gideon echoes Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3-4). The shrinking army anticipates 1 Samuel 14:6 and 2 Chronicles 20. The smashing of the jars to reveal the light is echoed in 2 Corinthians 4:7, "we have this treasure in jars of clay." The ephod's failure recalls the golden calf of Exodus 32. Gideon appears in Hebrews 11:32 as a man of faith. The principle of strength through weakness is expressed in 1 Corinthians 1:27-29.

STEP 6

Application

Think of how God sees you. Gideon was addressed as a "mighty man of valor" while he was hiding. In Christ, you are called a saint, a child of God, and a new creation. Ask the Lord to help you live into what he says you are.

Examine the "ephod" risk. After a spiritual success, we can be tempted to build a monument to ourselves or to something that distracts from God. What victories in your life might become a snare if you start to trust them?

Finally, embrace your weakness. If you feel inadequate for what God has put before you, hear the point of the 300. He chooses small instruments so that the glory is his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to tear down the idols in your house.
- Thank him that he wins with the weak, and tell him where you feel weak.
- Ask him to keep you from boasting in yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 221 · WEEK 32

Judges 9:1-10:18

Abimelech's treachery; the parable of the trees

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 9:1-10:18. This is one of the darkest stretches of the book. Abimelech, Gideon's son, murders his brothers and makes himself king. Read Jotham's parable of the trees carefully. It is a sharp piece of political satire with a prophetic punch.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Gideon has died, and Israel immediately returns to the Baals. Gideon's son by a concubine, Abimelech, sees an opportunity. He persuades the leaders of Shechem to make him king, and then he murders seventy of his half-brothers on a single stone. One brother, Jotham, escapes, and from the top of Mount Gerizim he tells a parable. This chapter is a warning about what happens when power is seized by a man with no fear of God. It is also a sign that Israel is sliding from a nation of tribes toward a kingdom, but toward the wrong kind of king. The chapter closes with two more brief judges, Tola and Jair, and another round of oppression.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abimelech persuades his mother's family to say to the leaders of Shechem, "Which is better for you, that all seventy of the sons of Jerubbaal rule over you, or that one rule over you?" (9:2).
2. The leaders give him seventy pieces of silver from the temple of Baal-berith, and he hires worthless and reckless fellows (9:4).
3. He kills his seventy brothers "on one stone," but Jotham, the youngest, hides (9:5).
4. Jotham's parable: the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine each refuse to rule, but the bramble agrees (9:7-15).

5. Jotham says, “let fire come out from Abimelech and devour the leaders of Shechem” (9:20).
6. “God sent an evil spirit between Abimelech and the leaders of Shechem” (9:23).
7. A woman drops a millstone on Abimelech’s head, and he asks his armor-bearer to kill him so that it will not be said a woman killed him (9:53-54).
8. “Thus God repaid the evil of Abimelech… and the evil of the men of Shechem God also repaid” (9:56-57).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Abimelech is a picture of the corruption of power. His name means “my father is king,” which says everything about his ambitions. He uses his family connections, the money from a pagan temple, and a gang of thugs to take control. The leaders of Shechem, who make him king, are complicit. They are willing to trade their loyalty to Jerubbaal’s family for a more convenient ruler, and they fund him from the treasury of Baal. The corruption is spiritual and political at once.

Jotham’s parable is the intellectual heart of the chapter. The trees go out to anoint a king. The olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine are all fruitful and useful, and each declines the offer, preferring to continue producing good things. Only the bramble, which produces nothing and is only good for burning, accepts. The sharp point is that those worth following have better things to do than seek power, and those who crave it are often the least fit. The bramble’s offer, “take refuge in my shade,” is absurd. A bramble offers no shade, and a fire may come from it.

The prophecy comes true. Within three years, God raises up strife between Abimelech and Shechem. The conspirators turn on each other, and both are destroyed. The narrator says plainly that God was repaying the evil done to the house of Gideon. The chapter is a case study in justice working itself out through the very sins people commit. Those who live by violence die by violence. Abimelech is killed by a millstone dropped from a tower by a woman, and his death is a bitter mockery of his pride.

The meaning is hardly cheerful, but it is clear. Human kingship without God is a bramble. It grasps, it burns, and it destroys. This sets the stage for a longer story. Israel will ask for a king in 1 Samuel, and the first, Saul, will be a disappointment. Only David will be a man after God’s own heart, and even he will fail. The longing for a true king runs through the whole Old Testament. The perfect king is the one who did not grasp at power but took the form of a

servant. Philippians 2:5-8 describes the opposite of Abimelech. Christ, who had every right to rule, humbled himself and died. The true king is the true olive tree, the one who does not seek his own glory but gives himself.

Chapter 10 closes with a short note on two minor judges and then a statement of Israel's apostasy: they serve the Baals, the Ashtaroth, and the gods of seven nations. God finally says, "I will save you no more," but when they put away their foreign gods, "he became impatient over the misery of Israel." His compassion overcomes his anger.

STEP 5

Connection

Abimelech's story echoes Cain's murder of Abel (Genesis 4) and Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 15). The parable of the trees is a fable like Nathan's parable in 2 Samuel 12. The woman and the millstone appear again in 2 Samuel 11:21. Shechem was the place of the covenant in Joshua 24, and its fall here shows how far Israel has drifted. The true King contrasts with the bramble in Philippians 2:5-11 and Mark 10:42-45.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself what drives your ambitions. Are there areas where you are grasping for position, recognition, or control? Pray over them, and ask the Lord to give you the humility of Christ.

Consider whom you follow. The leaders of Shechem chose a bramble because he was convenient. Do you hold your leaders, in church, work, and society, to the standard of Scripture? Pray for those in authority over you.

Finally, take comfort that God sees. Abimelech's crimes were hidden from earthly justice for a time, but not from God. Trust him to repay evil, and don't take revenge into your own hands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from grasping for power.
- Ask him for the heart of the servant king.
- Pray for leaders who fear him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 222 · WEEK 32

Judges 11:1-12:15

Jephthah's vow; the Ephraimites

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 11:1-12:15. This reading includes the story of Jephthah, whose rash vow leads to tragedy, and a brief conflict with the Ephraimites. Read it slowly and with care. It is one of the hardest narratives in the book, and the text does not tell us how to feel about it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is again oppressed, this time by the Ammonites. The elders of Gilead go to Jephthah, a mighty warrior who had been driven out by his half-brothers because his mother was a prostitute. They ask him to lead them. Jephthah negotiates, makes a speech in which he recounts Israel's history, and is empowered by the Spirit of the LORD. Then he makes a vow that will cost him dearly. The story reflects an Israel so far from the knowledge of God that even a judge, a man of faith in Hebrews 11, can act in ignorance and desperation. The chapter is a warning about the danger of vows made without thought.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jephthah is the son of a prostitute, rejected by his brothers, and gathers "worthless fellows" around him (11:1-3).
2. The elders say, "Come and be our leader." Jephthah says, "Did you not hate me and drive me out of my father's house?" (11:6-7).
3. Jephthah recounts the history of Israel's journey to the Ammonite king, arguing that God, not Israel, took the land (11:12-28).
4. "Then the Spirit of the LORD was upon Jephthah" (11:29).

5. He vows: “If you will give the Ammonites into my hand, then whatever comes out from the doors of my house to meet me… shall be the LORD’s, and I will offer it up for a burnt offering” (11:30-31).
6. The LORD gives the victory, and his only child, a daughter, comes out to meet him with tambourines and dancing (11:34).
7. She says, “My father, you have opened your mouth to the LORD; do to me according to what has gone out of your mouth” (11:36).
8. The Ephraimites quarrel, and 42,000 are killed at the fords of the Jordan, identified by their failure to say “Shibboleth” (12:1-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jephthah’s story starts with rejection. He is an outcast, driven away by his family, and he becomes a leader of a band of raiders. When the elders come crawling to him in trouble, he shows both pride and shrewdness. He extracts a promise that, if he wins, he will be their head. There is a note of dignity in this. Yet his speech to the Ammonite king shows real knowledge of Israel’s history. Jephthah knows the Scriptures. He argues from Numbers and Deuteronomy, and he says, “Let the LORD, the Judge, decide.” This is not an ignorant man.

And yet he makes the vow. After the Spirit of the LORD comes upon him, he makes a vow that nobody asked for. The vow assumes that God needs to be bargained with. “If you will give… then I will offer.” The Spirit had already come. The victory was already promised. The vow shows insecurity, a desire to buy what God had freely offered. The vow is a tragic confusion of grace and transaction.

The question of what happened to his daughter is debated. Some interpreters argue that Jephthah did offer her as a burnt sacrifice, and the narrative’s grief supports that. Others suggest that she was given to lifelong service at the sanctuary, unmarried, which also explains the two-month mourning of her virginity. The text is ambiguous, but the heaviness is clear. In any reading, a rash vow has cost two lives, a father’s hope and a daughter’s future. The law of Moses condemned human sacrifice (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 12:31), and it also provided ways to redeem a vow (Leviticus 27). Jephthah either did not know them or did not trust them. Ignorance of the word of God leads to disaster.

What is the reader to take from this? The book of Judges never presents Jephthah as a model. He is listed in Hebrews 11 among those who by faith conquered kingdoms, but that does not mean everything he did was right. Faith can coexist with great failure. The book of Judges is showing how deep the confusion is in Israel when God’s word is not known. “Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.” Even those with real faith are bent by their culture.

The story of the Ephraimites at the Jordan fords is another sign of decay. The tribes are fighting each other, and 42,000 die over wounded pride. The word “Shibboleth” has become a symbol for any test that separates insiders from outsiders. Israel has a civil war within a few years of victory. Without a king, without knowing the LORD, the unity of the nation is falling apart.

STEP 5

Connection

The law about vows is in Numbers 30, Leviticus 27, and Deuteronomy 23:21-23, and Ecclesiastes 5:2-5 warns against rash vows. The prohibition of child sacrifice is in Leviticus 18:21 and Deuteronomy 18:10. Jephthah is named in Hebrews 11:32 and 1 Samuel 12:11. The pattern of an outcast who rescues his people anticipates Joseph and David, and ultimately Christ, who was rejected by his own (John 1:11). Abraham’s willingness to offer Isaac (Genesis 22) contrasts with God’s provision of a substitute.

STEP 6

Application

First, be careful with promises to God. Do not bargain with him as though he needs persuasion. He has already given what is best in Christ. Consider whether you have made commitments in a rush of emotion that you now need to bring honestly to him.

Second, study God’s word so you are not led by guesswork. Jephthah’s tragedy came in part from not knowing, or not trusting, what God had said. Choose a book of the Bible to read slowly over the next month.

Third, grieve with the daughter. The text invites sorrow. Pray for those in your life who have suffered because of a leader’s foolishness, and ask God to bring justice and healing.

Finally, rejoice that God did not require a human sacrifice. Instead, he provided his own Son.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray for those who suffer from foolish vows and ignorance of God’s word.

Thank God that you do not need to bargain, because he gave his own Son.

Ask him to teach you to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 223 · WEEK 32

Judges 13:1-14:20

Samson's birth; his Philistine wife

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 13:1-14:20. The reading introduces Samson, the most famous and the most troubling of the judges. As you read, notice how the story starts with a promising birth and a faithful couple, and slowly turns into a man ruled by his appetites. Keep in mind that his strength is a gift of the Spirit and not of his muscles.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has done evil again, and this time the oppressor is the Philistines, who will remain a threat until the time of David. There is a significant difference from the earlier cycles. This time, Israel does not cry out to the LORD. The text does not mention any repentance. God acts on his own initiative. He sends the angel of the LORD to a barren woman in the tribe of Dan, the wife of Manoah, and announces the birth of a son who will begin to save Israel. The stories of Samson open with a miracle birth, but they will end in blindness and death. Samson is a figure of tragic gift: a man consecrated to God from the womb who lives like everyone else.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The people of Israel again did what was evil in the sight of the LORD, and the LORD gave them into the hand of the Philistines forty years" (13:1).
2. The angel of the LORD appears to Manoah's barren wife and says she will conceive a son who will be a Nazirite "from the womb" (13:3-5).
3. The boy is to have no razor on his head and not to drink wine, and he "shall begin to save Israel from the hand of the Philistines" (13:5).

4. Manoah prays for the angel to return, and the angel ascends in the flame of the altar (13:8-20).
5. Manoah says, "We shall surely die, for we have seen God," and his wife reasons that if the LORD wanted to kill them, he would not have accepted their offering (13:22-23).
6. "The boy grew, and the LORD blessed him. And the Spirit of the LORD began to stir him" (13:24-25).
7. Samson demands a Philistine wife: "Get her for me, for she is right in my eyes" (14:3).
8. The text says that this "was from the LORD, for he was seeking an opportunity against the Philistines" (14:4).
9. Samson kills a lion with his bare hands, poses a riddle, and loses his wedding bet through his wife's betrayal (14:5-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening chapter is one of the most beautiful in the book. A barren woman, like Sarah, Rebekah, and Rachel, is visited by God. Like Hannah later and Elizabeth after her, she will bear a child through divine intervention. The pattern is familiar: God overcomes human inability to bring salvation. The angel's instructions emphasize that the boy is to be set apart from birth. The Nazirite vow, described in Numbers 6, included abstaining from wine, avoiding contact with the dead, and leaving the hair uncut. It was a visible sign of consecration.

Notice the contrast between Manoah and his wife. Manoah is fearful and cautious. His wife is perceptive and calm. When the angel ascends in the fire, Manoah despairs. His wife reasons from God's character: if he intended to destroy us, he would not have accepted our sacrifice or told us these things. Her theology is sound, and it is a model of how to reason from the grace of God. She understands that God's gifts are signs of his favor.

Then Samson grows up, and the Spirit begins to stir him, but the next scene is troubling. He sees a Philistine woman and demands, "Get her for me, for she is right in my eyes." This phrase is the key to the whole book. "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." Samson is the embodiment of the age. The man consecrated to God is governed by what he sees. His parents object, and the text tells us they did not know that this was from the LORD, who was seeking an opportunity against the Philistines. This is a paradox: God uses Samson's sin to accomplish his purposes. It does not excuse Samson. It shows that God's plans are not thwarted by human weakness.

The lion episode reveals the source of his power: “the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon him.” His strength is not physical. It is a gift. Yet he does not tell his parents about the lion or the honey in its carcass, a hint that he has already violated his Nazirite vow by touching a carcass. His riddle at the wedding feast is built on a secret he cannot share, and he loses it to his wife’s tears. The story is a catalog of the ways a man can squander a gift.

Samson is a tragic figure, but he also points forward. His miraculous birth, his consecration, and his role as a deliverer anticipate Christ. But he is a shadow, not the substance. Where Samson indulged his appetites, Jesus resisted the tempter in the wilderness. Where Samson was blinded, Jesus gives sight to the blind. Where Samson finally pulled down a temple in death, Jesus’s death tore the veil of the temple and set people free.

STEP 5

Connection

The Nazirite vow is described in Numbers 6:1-21. The barren-mother pattern appears in Genesis 18, 25, 29, 1 Samuel 1, and Luke 1. The angel of the LORD who ascends in fire recalls Genesis 16 and Exodus 3. The Spirit rushing upon Samson is echoed in Judges 3:10, 6:34, and 11:29, and in 1 Samuel 10:6. Hebrews 11:32 includes Samson. Jesus’s birth, consecration, and victory over Satan contrast with Samson’s failures (Luke 1-4).

STEP 6

Application

First, let Manoah’s wife teach you to reason from God’s grace. When you are afraid, ask what God has already done. His gifts and promises are signs of his intention to bless.

Second, examine what is “right in your eyes.” Samson’s downfall began with what he saw. What do you look at, and what do you pursue because it looks good? Bring your desires before the Lord and ask for his wisdom.

Third, remember that your gifts are not your own. Samson’s strength came from the Spirit. Whatever abilities you have, thank God for them and use them for his purposes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for gifts you did not earn.

Ask him to keep you from living by what is right in your own eyes.

Ask him for faithfulness in your calling.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 224 · WEEK 32

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you sang two psalms of God's power over the nations and followed the judges Gideon, Abimelech, Jephthah, and the opening of Samson's story. Rest today in the single truth that runs through all of it: God saves by his own strength, usually through weak instruments.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

ZECHARIAH 4:6

REST

Meditation

Zechariah 4:6 comes from a later prophet speaking to a discouraged remnant, but it sums up what this week's readings have been saying.

"Not by might." The word refers to an army or strength in numbers. Gideon began with 32,000 and ended with 300. God does not need a big force. He often deliberately reduces ours so that we cannot take credit.

"Nor by power." The second word refers to individual strength or ability. Samson was the strongest man in Israel, and his strength led to his ruin. Power in our hands is dangerous because it can lead us to trust ourselves.

"But by my Spirit." This is the center. God works through the Spirit, who rushed upon Gideon and stirred Samson. The Spirit is not a force we control but the presence of God himself, accomplishing what we cannot.

“Says the LORD of hosts.” The speaker is the commander of the armies of heaven. His word has the authority of the one who rules all.

For the Christian, this verse is a daily corrective. We are tempted to evaluate our usefulness by our abilities, our resources, or our results. The verse reminds us that God’s work is done by his Spirit, who lives in every believer. Our task is to depend, to obey, and to leave the results to him. Memorize the verse and carry it into whatever feels too big this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began with Psalm 46 and Psalm 76, two songs of Zion that celebrate God’s power over chaos and the nations. You heard the command, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Then you read the great cycle of judges. You followed Gideon from the winepress to the 300 and saw how a victory became a snare. You read about Abimelech, the bramble king, whose reign ended with a millstone. You read the sad story of Jephthah’s rash vow and the civil war with Ephraim. And you met Samson, born to a barren woman and consecrated from the womb, yet already living by what was right in his own eyes.

The week showed a pattern: God keeps using weak and flawed people, because his power does not depend on theirs.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where are you tempted to rely on your own strength? Gideon’s army was reduced so that Israel could not boast. Think of an area of life, such as your work, parenting, ministry, or relationships, where you feel pressure to produce results. What would it look like to depend on the Spirit instead?

How does the failure of the judges point you to Christ? Every judge was flawed. Gideon made an idol, Jephthah made a rash vow, and Samson followed his eyes. The book leaves us longing for a perfect deliverer. How does Jesus fulfill what they could only hint at? What does it mean to you that he is both the true Judge and the one who was judged in your place?

What “bramble” offers might be tempting you? Jotham’s parable warns that those who crave power or comfort are often not fit to lead. Are there voices or goals in your life that promise shade but are likely to burn? Who in your life models the humility of the olive tree and the vine?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for saving through weak and flawed people.

Admit that you cannot save yourself, and rest in Jesus, the perfect deliverer.

Rest in his strength today.

DAY 225 · WEEK 33

Judges 15:1-16:31

Samson's exploits; Delilah; his death

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 15:1-16:31. These chapters finish the story of Samson, from his revenge on the Philistines through Delilah and his death in the temple of Dagon. Read slowly through chapter 16, and watch for the quiet sentence in verse 20: "he did not know that the LORD had left him."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Samson's wedding has ended in betrayal, and his violence against the Philistines escalates. In the stories you read today, he burns their fields with foxes, kills a thousand men with a donkey's jawbone, carries off the gates of Gaza, and then falls in love with Delilah. The text is brutally honest about a man with enormous gifts and no self-control. Samson never leads Israel into freedom, and the Philistines are not defeated in his lifetime. But the story ends with a surprising prayer. The man who lived by his eyes is blinded, humbled, and finally turns to the LORD. His last act is a sacrifice that begins the work God promised.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Samson burns the Philistines' grain with three hundred foxes and torches (15:4-5).
2. The men of Judah, afraid of the Philistines, bind Samson and hand him over; the Spirit rushes upon him, and he kills a thousand with the jawbone of a donkey (15:9-15).
3. Thirsty, Samson cries out to the LORD, and God splits a hollow place so that water comes out (15:18-19).
4. He visits a prostitute in Gaza and carries off the city gates on his shoulders (16:1-3).
5. "He loved a woman in the Valley of Sorek, whose name was Delilah" (16:4).

6. Delilah pressures him day after day until "his soul was vexed to death," and he tells her the secret of his hair (16:16-17).

7. "He did not know that the LORD had left him" (16:20). The Philistines gouge out his eyes and set him to grind at the mill.

8. Samson prays, "O Lord GOD, please remember me and please strengthen me only this once," and pulls down the temple, killing more in his death than in his life (16:28-30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Samson is a study in contradictions. He is the Spirit-empowered deliverer, and the Spirit comes on him again and again. And yet his life is marked by appetite, revenge, and carelessness. The text never excuses him. Chapter 15 shows his motives to be personal grudges: "As they did to me, so have I done to them." He is not fighting a holy war for Israel. He is settling scores. Even when he is thirsty and cries out to God after a great victory, his prayer includes the complaint, "Shall I now die of thirst?" God still answers him with water. The mercy of God is bigger than Samson's failings.

Chapter 16 tells the tragedy of Delilah. Samson goes to Gaza for a prostitute and then falls in love with a woman who is paid to betray him. The details of the story are almost comic, three times he lies about the secret of his strength and three times she tries it out. And yet he keeps flirting with danger. He is like a man playing with fire, convinced he will not be burned. When Delilah's nagging wears him down, he tells her everything. The cutting of his hair is not magic. It is the final break of a Nazirite vow that he had long been violating. The real loss is described in verse 20: "he did not know that the LORD had left him." This is one of the most chilling sentences in the Bible. He wakes up and says, "I will go out as at other times." He assumes the power will be there. But it is gone.

The consequences are severe. The Philistines gouge out his eyes. The man who followed his eyes into sin is now blind. They put him in bronze shackles to grind at the mill, like an animal. And they celebrate in the temple of Dagon, praising their god for delivering Samson into their hands. This is the lowest point, because the name of the LORD is being mocked.

But the story has one more turn. Samson's hair begins to grow. In the dark, he turns to prayer. The prayer is short, and it is the first time in the story he calls on God as "Lord GOD" with personal appeal, asking to be remembered. His request is for vengeance, but it is also for the vindication of God's name. God answers. Samson pushes the pillars, and the temple falls. "So the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those he had killed during his life."

Samson is not a model of holiness. But he is a sign of God's grace. Hebrews 11:32 lists him among those commended for faith, which suggests that his last prayer was a genuine act of trust. The same grace reaches the worst of us. His story also points to a greater one: a Savior who is delivered to the enemy, bound, mocked, and who by his death destroys the power of those who hold his people captive. Jesus did what Samson only pictured.

STEP 5

Connection

Samson's story fits the pattern of Judges' downward spiral. The Nazirite vow is in Numbers 6. The loss of the Spirit echoes Saul in 1 Samuel 16:14. The temple of Dagon appears again in 1 Samuel 5. Hebrews 11:32 includes Samson, and Matthew 27:35-44 shows Jesus mocked by his captors and conquering through death. Colossians 2:15 and Hebrews 2:14-15 describe Christ's defeat of the powers through death.

STEP 6

Application

Take the warning of verse 20 seriously. Spiritual drift is often not dramatic. It happens in small compromises that dull our sensitivity until we do not notice that God's presence has become faint. Ask yourself honestly: when did you last feel a sense of God's nearness? What may have been dimming it?

Second, guard your eyes and your heart. Decide on one specific boundary this week that will protect you from a recurring temptation.

Third, take hope from Samson's last prayer. No matter how far you have fallen, God hears the cry of a humbled heart. Return to him today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God where you are gifted yet careless.

Ask him to open your eyes to your own heart before the drift goes further.

Thank Jesus for remembering and saving you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

“O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.”

PSALM 130:7

DAY 226 · WEEK 33

Psalm 130

Out of the depths I cry, hope in God's redeeming love

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 130 slowly. It is a Song of Ascents and one of the seven penitential psalms. It begins in the depths and ends with a hope for all Israel. Read it twice, once as a personal prayer of repentance and once as a word of encouragement to others.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the dark stories of the judges, this psalm is a breath of hope. It speaks out of the "depths" of sin and sorrow, and it finds its way upward by clinging to the character of God. The psalmist does not minimize his guilt. He says that if God marked iniquities, no one could stand. But with the LORD there is forgiveness, and that is why he is feared. For a people reading Judges, who cycle in rebellion and rescue, this psalm shows where the cycle can be broken: in a heart that waits on God's forgiveness and redeeming love. It is also the psalm Martin Luther loved most, and one that Christians have sung for centuries.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD! O Lord, hear my voice!" (vv. 1-2).
2. "If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?" (v. 3).
3. "But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared" (v. 4).
4. "I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope" (v. 5).
5. The psalmist waits "more than watchmen for the morning" and repeats it for emphasis (v. 6).
6. The word "wait" occurs several times, and the whole psalm has the movement of hope.

7 “O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption” (v. 7).

8 “And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a cry from “the depths,” a word that suggests deep water. The psalmist is drowning, not in an external threat but in his own sin. He does not pretend. He knows that if God kept a ledger of sins, no one could stand. This is not hyperbole. It is the honest conclusion of anyone who has seen their heart. Romans 3:23 says, “All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.” The psalmist’s rescue does not begin with a promise that he is better than he thinks. It begins with the character of God: “But with you there is forgiveness.”

Notice the surprising reason: “that you may be feared.” We might expect forgiveness to lead to relief or love, and it does. But here forgiveness leads to reverence. A God who forgives is more awesome than a God who merely punishes. Forgiveness shows that he is both holy enough to condemn and gracious enough to pardon. The proper response is awe, and not casual indifference. Those who think forgiveness is cheap have not understood what it cost.

The next verses describe waiting. The psalmist waits for the LORD, and he waits in the word. He does not simply hope in a vague sense. His hope rests on what God has said. Then he uses a vivid image: “more than watchmen for the morning.” A night watchman on the walls of a city looks for the dawn with intense longing. The first light means that the dangerous hours are over. The psalmist says his waiting is like that. He is sure the morning will come.

Then the psalm turns outward. The one who has found forgiveness cannot keep it private. “O Israel, hope in the LORD!” Personal experience leads to public testimony. The reasons given are “steadfast love” (the covenant faithfulness, hesed) and “plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” suggests that God’s supply of mercy is more than enough for the sins of his people. And the final verse is a promise: “he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.” Not from some, but all.

For the Christian, this is the psalm of the cross. The “plentiful redemption” is purchased by the blood of Christ. “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace” (Ephesians 1:7). The depths into which we sank were entered by Jesus himself, who cried out in the darkness so that we would not have to.

STEP 5

Connection

This is one of the seven penitential psalms (6, 32, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143). The theme of forgiveness appears in Exodus 34:6-7 and Psalm 103:8-12. The watchman image recalls Isaiah 21:11-12 and Habakkuk 2:1. Paul cites the language of redemption in Ephesians 1:7 and Titus 2:14. Luke 1:68-79 echoes the hope for Israel's redemption.

STEP 6

Application

Name your "depths" honestly. What sin, regret, or weight are you carrying? Pray verses 1-4 in your own words. Do not skip to the hope before you have said the truth.

Then practice the watchman's waiting. Choose one thing you are hoping for from God, and set aside five minutes a day this week to wait on him in his word. Read a short passage, and ask what it says about his character.

Finally, tell someone. The psalm moves from "I" to "Israel." Share one way God's forgiveness has changed you with a friend, a family member, or a member of your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God out of your own depths, saying what you need.
- Thank him that with him there is forgiveness.
- Wait for him in your own words, trusting his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 227 · WEEK 33

Psalm 40:1-10

He drew me out of the pit, waiting and the new song

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10. The psalm moves from a testimony of patient waiting to a new song and then to a public declaration. Read it as the testimony of someone who has been rescued and cannot keep quiet. You will meet this psalm again in the book of Hebrews, where it is heard as the voice of Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the despair of Samson and the confession of Psalm 130, this psalm is the answer that follows a long wait. David has been in a pit, and God has lifted him out. This is a psalm of testimony and gratitude. Its opening verses are some of the best-loved in the Psalter. In this unit, we read it as a response to the story of Judges: when God's people cry out, he answers, and a new song follows. In the weeks ahead you will encounter it again in Hebrews, and see how its deeper meaning points to Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I waited patiently for the LORD; he inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. "He drew me up from the pit of destruction, out of the miry bog, and set my feet upon a rock, making my steps secure" (v. 2).
3. "He put a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God" (v. 3).
4. "Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD" (v. 3).
5. "Blessed is the man who makes the LORD his trust" (v. 4).
6. "Many, O LORD my God, are the wonders you have done, and your thoughts toward us" (v. 5).

7. “Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear” (v. 6).
8. “I have told the glad news of deliverance in the great congregation; behold, I have not restrained my lips” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the experience of waiting. “I waited patiently.” In Hebrew the phrase is intensive: “waiting, I waited.” It was a long season. The person who wrote this did not receive an instant answer. We often want God to rescue us quickly, and he may not. But the psalm says that in the waiting, he “inclined” to David and heard. The image is of someone bending down to hear a faint voice. God stoops to listen.

The pit is a vivid image of helplessness. The “miry bog” is a place where every effort to escape makes you sink deeper. David was unable to rescue himself. God lifted him out and set his feet on a rock. The contrast is physical: from sinking mud to solid stone. And then “making my steps secure.” The rescue is not only an escape but a new stability.

The new song is the natural response. God puts it in David’s mouth. The song is not a performance but a gift. And it has a purpose: “Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD.” David’s testimony is meant to draw others in. A rescued person is a living witness.

Verses 6-8 are the center of the psalm. David says that sacrifice and offering were not the thing God ultimately desired. What he wanted was a hearing heart, an “open ear,” and a life of obedience from within. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart.” David’s gratitude is not expressed in religious activity but in wholehearted obedience. This does not abolish sacrifice. It places it in its proper context. Outward rituals without inward devotion are empty.

The last verses commit David to public testimony. He has not hidden God’s righteousness in his heart. He has told the great congregation about God’s faithfulness and salvation. A person rescued from a pit has something to say. In the book of Hebrews, the middle verses are heard in the voice of Christ, who came into the world to do the Father’s will. You will read that when you reach Hebrews 10. For now, rejoice that God hears, lifts, and gives a new song.

STEP 5

Connection

The pit imagery recalls Joseph in Genesis 37, and Jeremiah 38 and Jonah 2. The new song appears in Psalms 33:3, 96:1, 98:1, and Revelation 5:9. The priority of obedience over sacrifice is in 1 Samuel 15:22, Psalm 51:16-17, and Hosea 6:6. Hebrews 10:5-10 quotes verses 6-8 as the words of Christ. Romans 10:9-10 links heart faith with public confession.

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a season of waiting, take heart. Read verse 1 slowly. God bends down to hear. Bring a specific request to him today, and commit to waiting on him without a deadline.

If God has rescued you from something, write out your "new song." It might be a paragraph describing what he did. Share it with someone this week.

Finally, ask yourself where your obedience has become outward only. Pray verse 8, "I delight to do your will," and ask the Spirit to write God's law within your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for drawing you out of a pit, and name one.
- Ask him to teach you to wait patiently and delight in his will.
- Ask him to give you a new song and someone to tell of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 228 · WEEK 33

Judges 17:1-18:31

Micah's idol; the Danites, religion as private property

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 17:1-18:31. These chapters begin the long appendix to the book of Judges, which shows how deeply Israel has fallen. Watch for the repeated phrase, "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." Notice how religion becomes a personal convenience.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The stories of the judges are over, but the book is not. The last five chapters tell two stories that illustrate the moral and spiritual collapse of the nation. The first, which you read today, is about a man named Micah from the hill country of Ephraim, his stolen silver, his private shrine, and a wandering Levite who is hired as his priest. The tribe of Dan then passes through, steals the idol and the priest, and conquers a peaceful city. The two stories show religion without God, worship shaped to the worshiper's tastes, and a priesthood for hire. They are told with dry irony, and they explain why the book keeps saying that Israel needed a king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Micah's mother has 1,100 pieces of silver stolen, and she pronounces a curse. When Micah confesses, she blesses him in the LORD's name (17:1-2).
2. She dedicates the silver to the LORD to make an idol, and Micah sets up a shrine with an ephod and household gods (17:3-5).
3. "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (17:6).

4. A young Levite from Bethlehem, looking for a place to live, agrees to be Micah's priest for ten pieces of silver a year (17:7-12).
5. Micah says, "Now I know that the LORD will prosper me, because I have a Levite as priest" (17:13).
6. The tribe of Dan, looking for land, sends spies, who consult the Levite and are told, "Your journey is under the eye of the LORD" (18:5-6).
7. The Danites steal Micah's idols and persuade the Levite to come with them: "Is it better for you to be priest to the house of one man, or to be priest to a tribe?" (18:19).
8. They destroy the peaceful city of Laish, rename it Dan, and set up the idol for themselves (18:27-31).
9. The author notes that the idol was there "all the time that the house of God was at Shiloh" (18:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Micah story is a careful satire. It begins with a theft and a curse, and the thief is the man's own son. The mother then blesses him in the LORD's name and dedicates the silver to the LORD, and promptly uses part of it to make an idol. Everything is mixed up. They use the name of the LORD, but they ignore his law. They speak of dedication, but they violate the second commandment. The household is spiritually confused, and nobody notices.

Micah's shrine is a religion of convenience. He has his own ephod, his own household gods, and his own priest. He even ordains his son. When a Levite from Bethlehem wanders by, Micah hires him, believing that he now has God's favor secured: "Now I know that the LORD will prosper me." He thinks he can buy blessing. The Levite, a man who should have been serving at the tabernacle and teaching the law, takes the job for ten pieces of silver a year and a suit of clothes. The point is that even those whose calling is to teach God's word have drifted.

The Danites arrive and complete the picture. They seek an inheritance, not trusting God to give them the land he had allotted. They consult the Levite, who gives a vague blessing: "Your journey is under the eye of the LORD." It is exactly what they want to hear. Then they take Micah's idol and the priest. When Micah protests, they threaten him. The Levite goes with them gladly. He finds the offer of a tribe more attractive than a household. His loyalty is to his own advancement.

The conquest of Laish makes the point. They attack a quiet city with no allies, “a people quiet and unsuspecting,” and burn it. They then set up the idol and appoint the priest. The narrator adds a quiet closing note: all this happened while God’s house was at Shiloh. The true worship was available, and they ignored it.

The whole story shows religion as private property. Each person designs his own faith. What is right in his own eyes becomes the standard, and even the name of the LORD is attached to it. This is not an ancient problem. It is the habit of our day: faith shaped to personal taste, clergy chosen by what they offer, and worship tuned to what feels right. The corrective is the word of God and a true king. Only Christ is the true priest and king, who cannot be bought and who does not tell us only what we want to hear.

STEP 5

Connection

The second commandment is in Exodus 20:4-6. The Levites’ calling is in Numbers 18 and Deuteronomy 33:8-10. Dan’s later role as one of the places where Jeroboam set up a golden calf appears in 1 Kings 12:28-30. The “no king” refrain recurs in Judges 18:1, 19:1, and 21:25. Compare the false teachers who say what people want to hear in 2 Timothy 4:3-4. Christ as the true priest and king appears in Hebrews 7.

STEP 6

Application

Test your own faith for “Micah’s shrine.” Are there areas where you have designed God to suit your preferences, such as a convenient view of sin, a comfortable church, or a vague spirituality? Ask the Lord to correct them with his word.

Think about who shapes your beliefs. Do you listen to those who tell you what you want to hear, or to those who tell you the truth? Seek out one person who will speak honestly.

Finally, thank God for the true priest who cannot be hired and the true king who rules in righteousness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you have shaped God to your tastes.

Ask him to teach you to worship him as he is, in spirit and truth.

Thank Jesus, the true priest.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

“O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.”

PSALM 130:7

DAY 229 · WEEK 33

Judges 19:1-21:25

The Levite's concubine; civil war, "no king in Israel"

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 83 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 19:1-21:25. This is the most disturbing section of the Bible, and it is meant to be. Read it carefully and prayerfully. Do not rush. The story is not an endorsement of what happens but a portrait of moral collapse. Pay attention to how the story echoes the sin of Sodom and to the closing verse of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second appendix to Judges, and it shows how far Israel has fallen. A Levite's concubine is raped and killed in Gibeah, a city of Benjamin, and the Levite sends her body in pieces throughout Israel to summon the tribes. The nation gathers in outrage, and a civil war follows that nearly wipes out the tribe of Benjamin. Then Israel, horrified by its own actions, tries to fix the problem by more violence and deceit. The story has no heroes. At its close, the author repeats his summary of the age: "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." The book of Judges ends in darkness because it needs a king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A Levite takes a concubine from Bethlehem, who goes back to her father's house, and the Levite goes to bring her back (19:1-3).
2. On the return journey, he refuses to lodge in Jebus, a foreign city, and chooses Gibeah, a city of Benjamin (19:11-15).
3. No one in Gibeah takes them in, until an old man from Ephraim offers hospitality (19:15-21).

4. Worthless men of the city surround the house and demand the Levite, as at Sodom, and the Levite sends out his concubine (19:22-25).
5. In the morning, the woman is found dead at the door, and the Levite cuts her body into twelve pieces and sends them throughout Israel (19:27-30).
6. All Israel assembles at Mizpah, and the tribe of Benjamin refuses to hand over the guilty men (20:1-13).
7. After a bloody civil war in which Israel loses tens of thousands in two defeats, Benjamin is almost destroyed, leaving 600 men (20:14-48).
8. Israel mourns, "Why has this happened in Israel, that today there should be one tribe lacking?" and then secures wives for the survivors by violence and deceit (21:1-23).
9. "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (21:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story is a descent into hell. The introduction is subtle: a Levite and his concubine, and a long trip made reluctantly. The Levite refuses to stay in a foreign city and chooses an Israelite one, assuming his own people will be safer. His assumption is exactly wrong. The scene at Gibeah deliberately echoes Genesis 19, where the men of Sodom demanded to abuse Lot's guests. The author wants us to see that Gibeah, a city in Israel, has become Sodom. The people of God have taken on the character of the nations.

The horror reaches its peak in the Levite's act of sending out his concubine. The text tells it without comment, and the lack of comment is the comment. No one comes out well. The Levite is a coward, the old man is willing to sacrifice his own daughter and the concubine, and the men of the city are monsters. Later, the Levite's account to the tribes is self-serving, leaving out his own role. The narrator's silence invites us to be shocked. This is what happens when a people live without the restraint of God's word.

The war that follows is complicated. Israel is right to demand justice, but the way they pursue it is flawed. They ask God, "Shall we go up?" and he says yes, but they lose twice, with great casualties. Only after weeping and fasting before the LORD do they win. The text shows a nation seeking God only in crisis, and acting mostly on emotion. The destruction of Benjamin is nearly complete. Then, in chapter 21, the people suddenly realize that they have nearly erased a tribe. They have sworn not to give their daughters to Benjamin, and they cannot fix it without another sin. They attack Jabesh-gilead and kidnap young women from Shiloh. Each solution produces a new crime. The vows, the violence, and the schemes are all expressions of a nation that has lost its moral compass.

The concluding verse is the book's thesis: no king, and everyone doing what is right in his own eyes. But note the quiet hope. Gibeah is Saul's hometown. Bethlehem is mentioned as the home of the Levite, and Bethlehem will be David's home. The book sets up the contrast between a king who fails and a king who shepherds. And behind both, the reader is meant to long for a king who is truly righteous.

Christians read this story as a call to see the depth of sin and the need for a Savior. If this is what human beings do when left to their own judgment, then law and good intentions are not enough. We need a new heart and a true king. The gospel is not a better idea. It is rescue from a disaster we cannot fix. Only Christ, who was himself handed over to wicked men, can heal what Judges 19-21 reveals.

STEP 5

Connection

The scene at Gibeah echoes Genesis 19 (Sodom). The cut body parts recall Saul's summons in 1 Samuel 11:7. Gibeah was Saul's hometown (1 Samuel 10:26). The refrain "no king" prepares for 1 Samuel 8. Hosea 9:9 and 10:9 refer to "the days of Gibeah" as a byword for corruption. Jesus, handed over to wicked men, is the true suffering king (Matthew 26-27). Romans 3:10-18 describes the universal reach of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Do not look away from this story. Let it increase your sense of what sin does and what Christ saves us from. Spend time in prayer for those who suffer sexual violence and abuse in our own day. Ask the Lord what you can do to protect the vulnerable, such as supporting a ministry, listening to someone's story, or speaking up.

Second, ask where "what is right in your own eyes" influences your decisions. Choose a recent decision and check it against Scripture. Was it guided by God's word or by your own reasoning?

Third, let the story deepen your longing for the true king. Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus," and mean it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray for those who suffer violence and betrayal.

Confess where you do what is right in your own eyes.

Pray for Christ's reign to be real in your life and in the church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 230 · WEEK 33

Ruth 1:1-2:23

Ruth's loyalty; arriving in Bethlehem; Boaz introduced

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ruth 1:1-2:23. After the darkness of Judges, the book of Ruth is a bright point of light. The story begins with famine and death, and ends with a field of barley and a kind landowner. Read it as a short story, paying attention to the characters and to the quiet working of God's providence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Ruth is set "in the days when the judges ruled." This is the same dark era, and yet the story is of ordinary faithfulness. A family from Bethlehem, whose name means "house of bread," leaves because of a famine and goes to Moab. There, the father and both sons die, leaving three widows. Naomi decides to return to Bethlehem, and her Moabite daughter-in-law Ruth refuses to leave her. The two women arrive in Bethlehem as the barley harvest begins. By chapter 2, Ruth is gleaning in the field of a man named Boaz. The narrator is quietly showing that even in the worst of times, God has not abandoned his people, and that he is working through unnoticed lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elimelech, Naomi, and their two sons leave Bethlehem for Moab because of famine (1:1-2).
2. Elimelech dies, and the sons marry Moabite women, Orpah and Ruth, and then die too (1:3-5).
3. Naomi hears that "the LORD had visited his people and given them food" and decides to return (1:6-7).

4. Orpah turns back, but Ruth clings to Naomi: "Your people shall be my people, and your God my God" (1:14-17).
5. Naomi tells the women of Bethlehem, "Call me Mara, for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me" (1:20).
6. They arrive "at the beginning of barley harvest" (1:22).
7. Ruth goes to glean and "happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz" (2:3).
8. Boaz says, "The LORD repay you for what you have done, and a full reward be given you by the LORD, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge" (2:12).
9. Naomi says Boaz is "one of our redeemers" (2:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with sorrow. A family leaves the land of promise for the land of Moab, a nation with a bitter history with Israel. The move seems rational, since there is food in Moab, but it leads to loss. In ten years, Naomi loses her husband and both sons. She returns to Bethlehem with nothing, convinced that the LORD has turned against her. "The hand of the LORD has gone out against me." Her grief is real, and the text does not scold her. But the narrator slips in a quiet word: Ruth is with her.

Ruth's vow is among the most famous speeches in the Bible. She is a Moabite, an outsider, with every reason to go home. Naomi tells her twice to leave. Instead she says, "Where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God." It is a statement of covenant commitment, not only to a mother-in-law but to the God of Israel. Ruth has chosen to take refuge under the wings of the LORD. Like Rahab, she is a Gentile who joins the people of God by faith. The contrast with Orpah is instructive. Orpah's decision is not evil, but it is the choice of the familiar. Ruth leaps into the unknown.

The return to Bethlehem is accompanied by honest grief. Naomi says to call her "Mara," bitter. She says she went away full and has returned empty. But she is wrong on one count: she has Ruth, and the harvest has begun. The narrator marks the timing: "at the beginning of barley harvest." God is already providing.

Chapter 2 introduces Boaz through a series of coincidences. Ruth "happened" to come to Boaz's field. This is the narrator's way of saying that God's providence is at work in ordinary events, without any miracle. Boaz is generous. He notices Ruth, protects her, tells her to drink from the workers' water jars, and makes sure extra grain is left for her. He has heard of

her loyalty, and he asks that she be rewarded by the God "under whose wings you have come to take refuge." His blessing is also an unwitting prayer for himself, since he will become the answer to it.

Naomi's response is a turning point. When she hears that Ruth was in Boaz's field, her tone shifts: "Blessed be he by the LORD, whose kindness has not forsaken the living or the dead!" She sees that God has not forgotten her. And she identifies Boaz as one of their "redeemers," a close relative who has the right and duty to restore a family's fortunes. This is the hinge of the story. The word "redeemer" will carry the book to its conclusion and ultimately to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Moab's history with Israel is in Genesis 19:30-38, Numbers 22-25, and Deuteronomy 23:3-6. Ruth's loyalty parallels Abraham's call in Genesis 12. The gleaning laws are in Leviticus 19:9-10 and 23:22. The "wings" image is in Psalm 91:4 and Psalm 36:7. The Redeemer language appears in Leviticus 25:25 and Isaiah 41:14. Ruth is named in Matthew 1:5. Bethlehem anticipates Micah 5:2 and Luke 2:4-7.

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are in a season that feels like Naomi's, empty or bitter, be honest with God, but watch for the signs of his provision. The barley harvest was already beginning. Write down three ways you have seen his kindness in the last month.

Second, learn from Ruth's loyalty. Is there a person in your life who needs someone to stay beside them? Choose one way to show loyal love this week.

Third, look for the "Boaz" in your community. Kind and generous people are signs of God's care. Thank one of them today.

Finally, remember that you too have come to take refuge under the wings of the LORD, and the one under whose wings you shelter is Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he works in quiet ways even in dark times.

Ask him to open your eyes to his provision when you feel empty.

Ask him to teach you to take refuge under his wings.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

“O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.”

PSALM 130:7

DAY 231 · WEEK 33

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the story of Samson, sang two psalms of waiting and hope, walked through the terrible last chapters of Judges, and began the book of Ruth. Rest today in the single hope that runs through it all: with the LORD there is steadfast love and plentiful redemption.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

REST

Meditation

Psalm 130:7 turns the week's darkness into hope. After the idols of Micah and the horrors of Gibeah, here is the word that tells us why God's people can keep going.

"O Israel, hope in the LORD!" This is a command and an invitation. The psalmist has been in the depths and has found his way up. Now he turns to the whole people and tells them to hope. Hope is not a feeling that arrives on its own. It is a decision to trust the one who has spoken.

"For with the LORD there is steadfast love." The Hebrew word is hesed, the covenant love that does not let go. It is the love Ruth showed to Naomi and the love God shows to his people. It does not depend on their performance. It is committed to them.

“And with him is plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” is a reminder that God’s supply is greater than our need. If your sin is great, his redemption is greater. The judges failed, and the people failed, but the redemption did not run out.

For the Christian, this verse points to Christ. “In him we have redemption through his blood” (Ephesians 1:7). The plentiful redemption has a name. Say the verse aloud, and carry it into any moment this week when you feel the weight of sin or the weariness of waiting. Hope in the LORD.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw both the lowest point of Israel’s history and the first light of recovery. You finished Samson’s story, with Delilah’s betrayal, the loss of his strength, and his last prayer. You sang Psalm 130, out of the depths, and Psalm 40, the testimony of one lifted from the pit. You read the stories of Micah’s private idol and the Danites’ theft, and you read the horror of Gibeah and the civil war that followed, ending with the line that explains it all: “In those days there was no king in Israel.” Then you turned to Ruth. You met a Moabite widow who clung to her mother-in-law and her mother-in-law’s God, a bitter Naomi who came home empty, and a generous Boaz in the barley field. The word “redeemer” appeared.

The week held a clear contrast: the nation of Israel did what was right in its own eyes, and a single woman chose to take refuge under the wings of the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you see yourself in the cycle of Judges this week? Think about the pattern: forgetting God, hitting trouble, crying out, being rescued, and drifting again. Where are you in that cycle right now? What would it look like to break the pattern with a deeper, daily dependence on God?

How does the “plentiful redemption” of Psalm 130 find its fullest meaning in Jesus? Judges ends with a nation that needs a true king and a redeemer. Ruth introduces a kinsman-redeemer who will rescue a family. How does Christ, the greater king and the greater redeemer, answer what Judges leaves unresolved? What does it mean for you that your sin is not too big for his redemption?

Who is your “Ruth” or “Naomi”? Think about the people who have shown steadfast loyalty to you, and the people who need it from you. Is there a person in your life who is bitter, empty, or alone? What is one way you could stay with them this coming week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his steadfast love and plentiful redemption.

Thank him that he never stopped working in the dark days.

Rest in him today.

DAY 232 · WEEK 34

Ruth 3:1-4:22

The kinsman-redeemer; redemption; the Davidic lineage

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ruth 3:1-4:22. The story reaches its climax at the threshing floor and the city gate. Watch how Boaz acts as a redeemer, and how the chapter ends with a genealogy. That list of names is the point of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The barley harvest is ending, and Naomi is thinking about Ruth's future. She devises a plan that is culturally daring: Ruth should go to the threshing floor at night and ask Boaz to act as the kinsman-redeemer. Boaz, who has already shown his generosity, is willing, but there is a closer relative who has the first right. Boaz goes to the city gate, the place of legal business, and settles the matter before ten elders. The story ends with a marriage, the birth of a son, and a genealogy that reaches to King David. For readers of Judges, this is a stunning turn: from "no king in Israel" to the line of the king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Naomi says, "My daughter, should I not seek rest for you, that it may be well with you?" (3:1).
2. Ruth lies at Boaz's feet at night, and asks him to "spread your wings over your servant, for you are a redeemer" (3:9).
3. Boaz blesses her: "You have made your last kindness greater than the first" and calls her "a worthy woman" (3:10-11).
4. He tells her that there is a redeemer nearer than he, and promises to settle the matter that day (3:12-13).

5. At the gate, Boaz tells the nearer redeemer about the land of Elimelech, and the man says he will redeem it. When Boaz adds that he must also take Ruth, the man declines (4:1-6).
6. Boaz declares before the elders that he will redeem the property and marry Ruth "to perpetuate the name of the dead in his inheritance" (4:9-10).
7. The women say to Naomi, "Blessed be the LORD, who has not left you this day without a redeemer" (4:14).
8. The child Obed is born, and the book ends with a genealogy: Obed fathered Jesse, and Jesse fathered David (4:17-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The scene at the threshing floor can be misunderstood by modern readers. Ruth's request, to "spread your wings over your servant," is a request for marriage and protection. The same word for "wings" was used by Boaz in chapter 2, when he prayed that Ruth would find refuge under the wings of the LORD. Now Ruth asks Boaz to be that refuge, and he is the answer to his own prayer. The scene is full of integrity. Boaz does not take advantage of the situation. He sends Ruth away before dawn to protect her reputation, and he deals with the legal question openly.

The core of the story is redemption. Under the law of Moses, a close relative could "redeem" a family member who had fallen into poverty by buying back land or marrying a widow to raise children in the dead man's name. The redeemer needed three things: he had to be a relative, he had to be able to pay, and he had to be willing. The nearer redeemer was a relative and was apparently able, but he was not willing when he learned the cost. Boaz is all three. He stands at the gate and takes on the burden of the family at personal cost.

Boaz's actions are a picture of Christ. He is a relative, close to those he redeems. He is able to pay the price. He is willing, even when it costs him. Jesus became our brother in flesh and blood (Hebrews 2:14-17) so that he could redeem us. He paid the price with his own blood (1 Peter 1:18-19), and he did so willingly. "For the joy that was set before him he endured the cross" (Hebrews 12:2). The story invites us to see ourselves in Ruth, a stranger who was brought in and given a name and a place.

The ending is a surprise. The women of Bethlehem celebrate with Naomi, and she who was empty is now full. The baby Obed is placed in her arms. And then the genealogy reveals the reason the story was preserved: Obed is the grandfather of David. The Moabite Ruth is the

great-grandmother of Israel's greatest king. And Matthew's Gospel will continue the list: David is the ancestor of Jesus Christ. The story that began in famine and death ends with the line of the Messiah.

The book of Judges ended with the cry for a king. Ruth does not answer it directly, but it provides the beginning of the answer. God is working, in obscure fields and city gates, through obedient and ordinary people, to bring about the king. Even in the days of the judges, God was preparing the way.

STEP 5

Connection

The kinsman-redeemer laws are in Leviticus 25:25-55 and Deuteronomy 25:5-10. The theme of redemption appears in Job 19:25, Isaiah 41-54, and Galatians 4:4-5. Ruth, a Moabite, is named in Matthew 1:5, and Rahab too. The genealogy of Perez, Judah's son, recalls Genesis 38 and 49:8-12. David's line leads to Christ in Luke 1:32 and Romans 1:3.

STEP 6

Application

First, receive Boaz as a picture of Christ. He is near, able, and willing. Consider what that means for the debts you cannot pay: guilt, shame, and failure. Say aloud, "I have a Redeemer."

Second, reflect on Boaz's integrity. In a situation where he could have taken advantage, he acted honorably and openly. Where do you face a similar temptation? Choose to act with integrity this week.

Third, take heart from the genealogy. God's work is often hidden in ordinary lives. The faithfulness of one widow, one landowner, and one baby changed history. Ask the Lord to use your small acts of obedience for purposes you may never see.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being a redeemer who is near, able, and willing.

Thank God for bringing a stranger into the line of the king, as he brought you in.

Ask him to make you faithful in ordinary things.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

“There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God.”

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 233 · WEEK 34

Psalm 127; Psalm 128

Unless the LORD builds the house

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 127 and Psalm 128 together. They are Songs of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on the way to Jerusalem. Both are about the home. As you read, think of Ruth and Boaz, and of the house that God builds from unlikely beginnings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the book of Ruth, these two psalms are a perfect pair. Both are short songs of the family, and both celebrate God's blessing on a household. Psalm 127 is attributed to Solomon, and it asserts that all human labor is vain unless the LORD is its builder. Psalm 128 describes the blessed family of the man who fears the LORD. Together, they answer the question raised by Judges and Ruth: what does a faithful household look like? It is not one that does what is right in its own eyes but one that depends on the LORD for its foundations.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Unless the LORD builds the house, those who build it labor in vain" (127:1).
2. "Unless the LORD watches over the city, the watchman stays awake in vain" (127:1).
3. "It is in vain that you rise up early and go late to rest, eating the bread of anxious toil; for he gives to his beloved sleep" (127:2).
4. "Behold, children are a heritage from the LORD, the fruit of the womb a reward" (127:3).
5. Children are "like arrows in the hand of a warrior" (127:4).
6. "Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD, who walks in his ways!" (128:1).
7. "You shall eat the fruit of the labor of your hands; you shall be blessed, and it shall be well with you" (128:2).

8. The wife is “like a fruitful vine” and the children “like olive shoots around your table” (128:3).

9. “May you see your children’s children! Peace be upon Israel!” (128:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 127 begins with a challenge to human self-sufficiency. We build, guard, and work, and the psalm says that all of it is empty unless God is in it. This does not mean we should stop working. It means we should stop trusting our work as the thing that holds our lives together. A house built without God may look strong, but it stands on sand. A city guarded only by human watchfulness is vulnerable. The anxious toil that robs us of sleep is a sign that we have forgotten who builds the house.

The surprising line is verse 2: “for he gives to his beloved sleep.” The phrase has a double meaning. God gives sleep to those he loves, and the sleep itself is a gift, even a form of worship. When we lie down in peace, we declare that the world does not depend on us. This is a lesson that fits well with the rhythm of weekly rest in this plan. The one who built the world did not need our help and can run it while we sleep.

The psalm then turns to children, a “heritage from the LORD.” In an age that sometimes sees children as a burden or an accessory, the psalm says that they are a gift, a reward, and arrows in a warrior’s hand. The image of arrows suggests purpose and direction. Children are to be shaped and sent out. The phrase, “He shall not be put to shame when he speaks with his enemies in the gate,” suggests that a family with strong children is a secure family.

Psalm 128 follows with a picture of the blessed home. The man who fears the LORD and walks in his ways will eat the fruit of his labor. His wife will be like a fruitful vine in the heart of his house, and his children will be like olive shoots around his table. These are images of vitality and community. The family is gathered, nourished, and growing. The psalm does not promise that all believers will have this exact family or experience. It describes the blessing that flows from the fear of the LORD, which includes the quiet joys of home, work, and table.

The psalm ends with a prayer for the larger community: “The LORD bless you from Zion! May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life! May you see your children’s children!” The blessing of the family is tied to the blessing of the people of God. And Christians read this in light of the greater household that Christ has built, the church. Jesus said, “I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18). Unless the LORD builds the house, we labor in vain. And he is building it.

STEP 5

Connection

The “builder” language echoes Solomon’s building of the temple in 1 Kings 5-8 and Proverbs 24:3-4. The anxious toil theme is in Matthew 6:25-34. The fruitful vine and olive imagery appears in Deuteronomy 8:8, Psalm 52:8, and Hosea 14:5-7. The household blessing links to Ruth’s story and the birth of Obed. The church as a house is described in Ephesians 2:19-22 and 1 Peter 2:5.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself where you are laboring in vain. Is there a project, a plan, or a worry that you are carrying as though it all depended on you? Read Psalm 127:1-2 aloud and give it to the Lord, naming it specifically.

Practice receiving sleep as a gift. Tonight, as you lie down, pray, “Lord, you hold everything, and I rest in you.”

If you are a parent, thank God for your children as a gift. If you are not, pray for the families in your church and look for a way to support one. Everyone has a part in the household of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess anxious toil, and name what you are working for.
- Ask God to give you sleep as a gift and to build what you cannot.
- Pray for the families around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

“There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God.”

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 234 · WEEK 34

Review and Reflection

Unit 8 review, Conquest & Settlement

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."
>
> JOSHUA 24:15

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 8.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Joshua 24:15 comes at the end of a long speech, and the whole of Judges shows what happens when it is forgotten. Say it aloud several times. Notice three things.

First, "But as for me." The sentence begins with a contrast. Others may choose differently. The gods of the Amorites and the gods beyond the river are all available. Joshua does not pretend there are no options, and he does not wait to see what the crowd decides. He makes a personal commitment.

Second, "and my house." The commitment extends to the household. Joshua takes responsibility for the spiritual direction of those under his care. This does not mean he can force their faith, but he will lead, teach, and set an example. The failure of the generation after Joshua is the failure to pass this on.

Third, "we will serve the LORD." The verb is "serve," meaning worship and obey. It is not a vague spirituality but a covenant loyalty. And the one served has a name: the LORD, who rescued Israel from Egypt and gave them the land. Joshua will go on to say that the people cannot do this in their own strength. We cannot either. The strength to serve is given by Christ. Pray this verse over your home, your relationships, and your calling.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 8 you have traveled through Joshua, Judges, and Ruth, the story of Israel's entry into the land and the long, painful years that followed. The unit began with God's commission to Joshua and the promise of his presence. You met Rahab, a Canaanite woman who confessed that the LORD is God, hung a scarlet cord, and was brought into the line of the Messiah. You watched the priests step into the Jordan, and you saw twelve stones piled up as a memorial. You saw Jericho fall by faith and obedience, and Israel stumble at Ai because of Achan's hidden sin. You read about the Gibeonite deception, the day the sun stood still, and the northern campaign.

You then studied the distribution of the land: Caleb's faithfulness at eighty-five, the Levites whose inheritance was the LORD himself, the survey of the remaining territory, the cities of refuge that point to Christ our refuge, and the near-war over the altar that was settled by Phinehas's careful inquiry. You heard Joshua's farewell and the great call, "Choose this day whom you will serve," along with the sober reminder that no one is able to serve a holy God in his own strength.

Judges opened with the incomplete conquest and the generation that did not know the LORD. You followed the repeating cycle of sin, oppression, cry, and rescue through Othniel, Ehud, Deborah and Barak, Gideon, Abimelech, Jephthah, and Samson. You saw how each judge was flawed, and how the nation slid toward idolatry and violence. The last chapters showed a people doing what was right in their own eyes, with the refrain "no king in Israel." Then Ruth lit a lamp in the dark: a Moabite widow who took refuge under the wings of the LORD, and a redeemer named Boaz who became the great-grandfather of King David.

Along the way, the Psalms gave you words for every season: the sea fleeing in Psalm 114, God's testing in Psalm 66, your portion in Psalm 16, the shepherd of Psalm 23, the refuge of Psalm 46, the warrior-judge of Psalm 76, the depths of Psalm 130, the new song of Psalm 40, and the house built by the LORD in Psalms 127 and 128.

The message of the unit is that God keeps his promises even when his people do not. The rest he gives is partial and fragile, and it points forward to a better Joshua, a better king, and a better Redeemer.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the conquest reveal about the holiness and justice of God?

Look back at Jericho, Achan, and the Gibeonites. The conquest was a judgment on nations whose sin had reached its full measure (Genesis 15:16), and it also showed that Israel itself was not exempt. Achan's sin brought judgment on Israel, and Rahab's faith brought rescue to a Canaanite. God's holiness is real, and his mercy reaches those who take refuge in him. Write a few sentences about how these chapters help you hold God's justice and mercy together. How does the cross, where judgment and mercy meet, bring this tension to its resolution?

What is the cycle in Judges, and how does it function as a mirror for our own hearts?

Recall the pattern: Israel did evil, God gave them into the hands of oppressors, they cried out, God raised up a deliverer, there was rest, and then they relapsed. The judges themselves were flawed, and the book ends in moral chaos. Look at your own life. Where do you see a similar pattern of forgetting, trouble, crying out, and rescue? How does the book make you long for a better deliverer? Write down how Christ breaks the cycle in a way the judges could not.

How does Rahab's story illustrate justification by faith?

Reread Joshua 2 and compare it with Hebrews 11:31 and James 2:25. Rahab was a Canaanite and a prostitute, outside the covenant, with no works to boast of. She heard what God had done, believed, and took refuge in the way of rescue he provided. The scarlet cord marked her house. She was saved by faith, and her actions showed her faith was real. Think about how her story anticipates the gospel. How does it clarify the relationship between faith, works, and the grace of God in Christ?

How does Boaz function as a kinsman-redeemer, and how does he point to Christ?

Return to Ruth 3-4. A redeemer had to be a relative, able to pay the price, and willing to do so. Boaz fulfilled all three. Jesus became our brother in flesh and blood, paid the price of his own life, and did so willingly, for the joy set before him. Consider your own story. What debts or burdens have you been unable to pay? Write a short prayer of thanks to Christ, your Redeemer, for what he has done on your behalf.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping every promise and going before his people.

Confess where you have done what is right in your own eyes.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.